



CITY: Pg 3

CM Gupta unveils major infra push



NATION: Pg 5

PM unveils connectivity projects worth Rs 18,680 cr in West Bengal



FILM: Pg 12

'We should subscribe to all kinds of cinema'

TWO MORE SHIPS THROUGH, 22 AWAIT PASSAGE

India threads the Hormuz needle

No LPG refill for piped gas users | Commercial LPG sale opens in 29 states, UTs

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Two Indian ships carrying LPG from the Gulf countries crossed the Strait of Hormuz early on Saturday, raising the number of Indian vessels safely passing through the war-hit, narrow shipping lane to three.

The remaining 22 ships on the west side of the strait are on standby as the Indian government engages with governments in the region for ensuring their safe passage. LPG carriers Shivalik and Nanda Devi are now headed to Mundra and Kandla ports in Gujarat, Rajesh Kumar Sinha, Special Secretary in Ministry of Shipping, told a media briefing.

The vessels are carrying 92,700 tonnes of LPG, he said adding Shivalik is likely to reach Mundra on March 16 and Nanda Devi is likely to dock at Kandla the next day.

Besides the safe passage being an important milestone for Indian diplomacy, the cargo they are carrying is considered critical as ship-



Liberia-flagged tanker Shenlong Suezmax, carrying crude oil from Saudi Arabia, that arrived clearing the Strait of Hormuz, is seen at the Mumbai Port in Mumbai

STRAIT WATCH

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» 'INDIA HAS ADEQUATE CRUDE OIL INVENTORIES, AND DOMESTIC REFINERIES ARE OPERATING AT FULL CAPACITY, ENSURING SUFFICIENT AVAILABILITY OF PETROL AND DIESEL ACROSS THE COUNTRY'

ping constraints had impacted cooking gas LPG supplies.

India imports 60 per cent of its LPG needs, with 85-90 per cent of this being sourced from Gulf countries like Saudi Arabia and the UAE who use the Strait of Hormuz as transit for shipping oil and gas to users. The strait has been effectively closed

since the first week of March.

The two ships were among the 24 stranded on the west side of the strait since the war broke out in the region.

Besides, four others were stranded on the east side. One of them, an India-flagged oil tanker, Jag Prakash, carrying gasoline from Oman to Africa, crossed

the war-hit strait on Friday.

Sinha said of the 22 remaining Indian-flagged vessels on the west side, six are LPG vessels, one is a liquefied natural gas (LNG) carrier, four are crude oil tankers, one is carrying chemical products, three are container ships and two are bulk carriers.

Hundreds of ships had been stranded in the narrow sea lane between Iran and Oman since the US and Israel launched attacks on Iran, and Tehran targeted the region in retaliation.

"Several of our ships remain on standby in the Gulf region. We propose to continue to remain in

Continued on P4

Climate crusader Wangchuk walks free after six months

NSA detention lifted to facilitate dialogue

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI/JODHPUR: Eminent climate activist Sonam Wangchuk was released from the central jail in Rajasthan's Jodhpur on Saturday, six months after he was detained under the stringent National Security Act (NSA) for allegedly inciting violence in the Union Territory of Ladakh.

An official said Wangchuk's wife, Gitanjali J Angmo, received him as he walked free hours after the Union home ministry revoked his detention. After the paperwork, Wangchuk left with Angmo in a private vehicle around 1pm.

Wangchuk, 59, was accused of misleading people through provocative mention of Arab Spring-style protests. The Union Home Ministry revoked his detention with "immediate effect", citing the need to facilitate "constructive and meaningful dialogue with all stakeholders."

The release came days before the Supreme Court is set to hear on March 17 a habeas corpus petition of Angmo

CENTRE'S MOVE

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over the activist's incarceration under the 1980 law, which allows detention for up to 12 months without trial.

Wangchuk was detained on September 26, two days after the protests over demands for statehood for Ladakh turned violent, leaving four people dead and 45 injured. The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) also launched a preliminary inquiry against an institute that Wangchuk founded.

The activist was kept in

Jodhpur Central Jail, where he had already undergone nearly half of the detention period stipulated under the Act, according to a statement issued by the Centre announcing the decision to revoke his detention "with immediate effect".

"He was released from jail at about 1 pm today following an order from the central government," Ratanada Police Station SHO Dinesh Lakhawat said in Jodhpur.

Continued on P4



Modi govt prepared to sacrifice India's agriculture for its own interest

Rahul Gandhi

In today's paper

...

BUSINESS

NO FERTILISER SHORTAGE: GOVT 2

CITY

MCD OKAYS STP PROJECT 3

NATION

CM SAI LAUNCHES 'GAUDHAM YOJANA' 5

INTERNATIONAL

RUSSIAN STRIKE KILLS 4 IN UKR 6

SPORT

HOCKEY: INDIA LOSE TO ENG 7

AMID US-S KOREA DRILLS

NK flexes muscles

SEOUL: North Korea on Saturday fired about 10 ballistic missiles toward the eastern sea, South Korea's military said, staging its own show of force as the rival South conducts a joint military exercise with the United States.



KEY POINTS

» The missiles were fired from an area near the North Korean capital of Pyongyang, but didn't immediately say how far they flew

» Japan's Defence Ministry said the weapons landed in waters outside the country's exclusive economic zone

» The launches came as the US and South Korean militaries conduct their annual springtime exercises

South Korea's Joint Chiefs of Staff said the missiles were fired from an area near the North Korean capital of Pyongyang, but didn't immediately say how far they flew. Japan's Defence Ministry said the weapons landed in waters outside the country's exclusive economic zone.

The South's Joint Chiefs said the military has stepped up surveillance and is maintaining readiness against possible additional launches while closely sharing information with the US and Japan.

The launches came as the US and South Korean militaries conduct their annual springtime exercises involving thousands of troops while the Trump administration also wages an escalating war in the Middle East.

The war has raised concerns about potential security lapses in South Korea, as local media — citing security camera footage and other images — have speculated that the US is relocating some missile

Continued on P4

UNVEILS ₹23K CR PROJECTS IN SILCHAR

Govt easing war impact, Cong fuelling panic: PM

MPOST BUREAU

SILCHAR: Asserting that the Centre was working to minimise the impacts of global conflicts on the people, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday alleged that the Opposition Congress was acting "irresponsibly" by trying to create panic in the country.

Addressing a public meeting in Assam's Silchar after unveiling projects worth over Rs 23,550 crore, Modi alleged that the Congress had ignored the development of the Northeast for decades, and allowed a drawing of the border during Independence that cut off Barak Valley's access to the sea.

"As the world is facing wars, our effort is to minimise their impact on the people of the country. The Congress should have performed the role of a responsible political party, but it failed to do so. It is trying to create panic among the people," he alleged.

"They do not have any vision either for Assam or the nation, but only know how to abuse Modi, spread rumours, lies, and create false reels to mislead people," he claimed. Modi also took on the Congress over its shirtless protest at the AI Impact Summit in Delhi last month, accusing the party of defaming the nation.

"The entire world is interested in AI, and the successful summit in Delhi was attended by global leaders, tech companies and their heads. But, the Congress tried to embarrass the country by indulging in a 'kapda phar' (tearing of clothes) exhibition," he said.

Modi said the entire country condemned "this vulgar" protest, but



“THEY DO NOT HAVE ANY VISION EITHER FOR ASSAM OR THE NATION, BUT ONLY KNOW HOW TO ABUSE MODI, SPREAD RUMOURS, LIES, AND CREATE FALSE REELS TO MISLEAD PEOPLE”

the "royal family of the Congress" is "patting themselves on the back".

"Congress is left with nothing but to tear its own clothes," he added.

Alleging that the Congress engages in activities against the nation's interest, the PM said it can never ensure the welfare of the people of any state.

"Congress is losing one election after another, and in the near future, the party will hit a century of its losses. The despair of its losses has led it to open a front against the nation, and its leaders are busy defaming the country," he said.

Modi alleged that the Congress kept the Northeast away from both "dil (heart) and Delhi", ensuring that development did not reach the region's people,

Continued on P4

'ENGAGED TO FIND CONSENSUS'

BRICS differ on West Asia conflict: India

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India on Saturday admitted that a common BRICS position on the West Asia conflict remains elusive due to "differing views" among member-nations and New Delhi is engaged to forge a consensus on the issue.

Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) Spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal, without naming any country, said some BRICS members are directly involved in the conflict, which has impacted finding a unified stance for the grouping.

India is the current chair of the influential bloc, which recently expanded to include Iran, the United Arab Emirates (UAE) and some other countries.



Iran's counter-offensive against the UAE and other Gulf nations following the February 28 US-Israel strikes on Iranian targets has triggered some disquiet within the grouping.

As the current chair of the BRICS, India is now navigating

the challenge of finding a common position for the bloc on the conflict.

"Some members of the BRICS are directly involved in the current situation in the West Asia region, which has impacted forging a consensus on a common BRICS

CONSENSUS ELUSIVE

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position on the ongoing conflict," Jaiswal said at a media briefing.

He said India has been facilitating discussions among the BRICS members through the Sherpa channel. The last Sherpa meeting was held virtually on March 12.

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US HITS IRAN ISLAND, WARNS OIL NEXT

Trump calls world to guard Hormuz

ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI/WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump on Saturday urged nations affected by Tehran's "attempted closure" of the Hormuz Strait to send ships to secure the narrow shipping lane crucial for global oil supplies as the war with Iran entered the third week.

In a post of Truth Social, Trump urged countries such as China, France, Japan, South Korea, the UK and others to send ships to the Hormuz Strait, asserting that the US will continue to bomb the shoreline and target Iranian ships and boats.

Starting February 28, the US and Israel have launched a massive joint attack on Iran and with Iran's retaliation, it has extended to the entire Gulf region. Iranian strikes in Hormuz have affected maritime traffic in the strait, which is crucial for global supply chains for crude and oil.

Trump said the US destroyed military sites on an island vital to Iran's oil network

WAR DRAGS ON

» An American official said 2,500 more Marines and an amphibious assault ship are being sent to the Middle East nearly two weeks into the war with the Islamic Republic

» Iran's joint military command reiterated its threat that it will attack the US-linked oil and energy facilities in the region if the Islamic Republic's oil infrastructure is hit



and warned that its oil infrastructure could be next if Iran continues to interfere with the passage of ships through the Strait of Hormuz.

Trump said US forces on Friday "obliterated" targets on Iran's Kharg Island, which is home to the primary terminal that handles the country's oil exports. The speaker of the Iranian parliament had warned that such strikes would provoke a new level of retaliation.

Meanwhile, an American official said 2,500 more

Marines and an amphibious assault ship are being sent to the Middle East nearly two weeks into the war with the Islamic Republic.

Iran has continued to launch widespread missile and drone attacks on Israel and neighbouring Gulf states, and effectively closed the Strait of Hormuz, through which a fifth of the world's traded oil passes, even as US and Israeli warplanes pummel military and other targets across Iran.

On Saturday, Iran's joint mil-

itary command reiterated its threat that it will attack the US-linked oil and energy facilities in the region if the Islamic Republic's oil infrastructure is hit.

Ebrahim Zolfaghari, spokesperson for the Khatam al-Anbiya Central Headquarters, warned they will target "all oil, economic, and energy infrastructures belonging to oil companies across the region that have American shares or cooperate with America."

The joint military command also threatened to attack cities in the United Arab Emirates, saying the US used "ports, docks and hideouts" within UAE cities to launch strikes on the islands, without providing evidence. It called on people to evacuate those areas where it said US forces were sheltering.

Iran's semi official Fars news agency Saturday said the US strikes caused no damage to oil infrastructure on the island.

It reported at least 15 explosions following the strikes, which it said targeted an air defence facility, a naval base, the airport

Continued on P4

Amit Shah says BJP to go solo in 2027 Punjab polls

MOGA (PUNJAB): Union Minister Amit Shah on Saturday asserted that the BJP will fight the 2027 polls on its own with the aim to form its government in Punjab, where it had only been a junior partner to SAD, and promised to bring an anti-conversion law and end the drug menace in

the state, urging voters to give the party one opportunity to bring change.

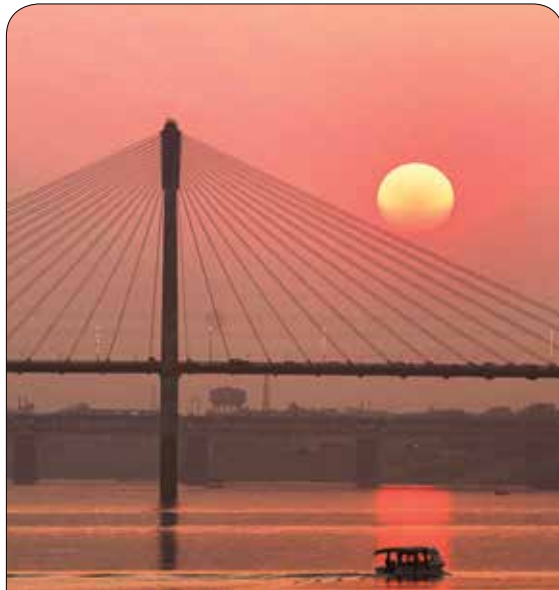
Sounding the poll bugle at a "Badlav" (change) rally in Moga, the senior BJP leader said that the people of the state have given many chances to Congress, Akalis and Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), but these

parties could not deliver.

"Today, Punjab has been destroyed due to debt, drugs, religious conversions, corruption and terror of gangsters," Shah said and asserted that only the BJP and Prime Minister Narendra Modi can rid the state of its problems.

See P4

SUNSET SERENITY



A boatman rows his boat in the Yamuna River during sunset, in Prayagraj, on Saturday

PTI

‘Govt ready to tackle rise in coal demand in summer’

‘Demand for coal increases in summer. Similarly, in winter, increased use of heaters boosts electricity needs’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHANDRAPUR: Union Minister G Kishan Reddy on Saturday said rising heat in the coming days with the onset of summer could push coal demand higher but the government is ready to tackle the situation.

He said coal companies are achieving extra production and the government is constantly communicating with them as part of efforts to meet any rise in demand.

“All coal requirements we produce domestically. In the coming days, rising heat could push coal demand even higher, but we are ready to fulfil the demand. Demand for coal increases in summer. Similarly, in winter, increased use of heaters boosts electricity needs, particularly in hilly areas where power demand spikes sharply,” he said.

The Union Minister of Coal and Mines was here to inaugurate the sustainable and scientific closure and repurposing of Western Coalfields Limited’s Murpar underground coal mine in Chimur in Chandrapur.

During the visit, he reviewed various activities and progress related to the closure of the mine, which began coal production in 2003 and was



The Union Minister of Coal & Mines G Kishan Reddy said coal companies are achieving extra production & the govt is constantly communicating with them as part of efforts to meet any rise in demand

closed in 2022 after the area was declared part of the Eco-Sensitive Zone of Tadoba-Andhari Tiger Reserve (TATR).

The closure of a mine is not an end but a new beginning towards sustainable development, he said at the event.

The mine closure process should be implemented in a scientific and systematic manner so that environmental balance can be restored and natural resources conserved after min-

ing operations cease.

“The interests of local communities should be given priority in mine closure plans.

Through various initiatives of the Union government, efforts are being made to transform closed mines into socially, economically, and environmentally useful assets,” he asserted.

Queried about WCL’s breakthrough in finding eight significant strategic minerals in its six mines in Maharashtra, Reddy

Highlights

» On WCL’s breakthrough in finding eight strategic minerals in its six mines in Maharashtra, he said the demand for these is very huge

» ‘The Union government has launched National Critical Minerals Mission, with a programme offering incentives worth around Rs 32,000 crore’

» ‘The mission’s objectives include exploring critical minerals, boosting mining activities & advancing development of these resources from abroad as well,’ he said

said the demand for these is very huge, especially amid the current geopolitical situation.

“Accordingly, the Union government has launched the National Critical Minerals Mission, with a programme offering incentives worth around Rs 32,000 crore. The mission’s objectives include exploring critical minerals, boosting mining activities, and advancing the development of these resources from abroad as well,” he said.

Remaining patient best strategy for investors amid uncertainties: Pandey

‘Past episodes of turbulence in markets like onset of the Covid-19 pandemic or the Russia-Ukraine conflict have shown that things stabilise eventually’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Sebi chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey on Saturday urged investors, especially retail ones, to remain patient, terming it the “best strategy” in uncertain times.

In remarks made amid the Middle East conflict-induced selling pressures in the markets, Pandey said past episodes of turbulence in markets like the onset of the Covid-19 pandemic or the Russia-Ukraine conflict have shown that things stabilise eventually.

The Sebi chief said global efforts are underway to restore stability, even as the ongoing tensions in parts of the world have created uncertainty in energy markets.

“For many investors — especially retail investors — the best strategy during such a period of uncertainty is to remain patient,” Pandey said, speaking at an event here.

The chief of the Indian capital markets regulator acknowledged that “uncertainty” dominates the global economic landscape, and added that the same is triggered by technology changes with the adoption of artificial intelligence and geopolitical tensions.

Citing past experience, Pandey said, “Markets experienced turbulence ... but they eventually stabilised.”



Sebi chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey

The Sebi chief said global efforts are underway to restore stability, even as the ongoing tensions in parts of the world have created uncertainty in energy markets

He went on to say that uncertainty is not an exception but a recurring feature in financial markets, and added that the real test of a system is to check if it continues to function smoothly, fairly and efficiently in the face of challenges.

“In uncertain times, the strength of a capital market does not lie in the absence of volatility. Volatility is a natural feature of markets. The real strength lies in the confidence that the system will function fairly, transparently and effi-

ciently even during periods of stress,” he said.

India’s capital markets can navigate the uncertainty and also emerge stronger if we continue to strengthen our institutions, deepen participation and uphold governance, the Sebi chairman said.

Efficient capital markets play a stabilising role in an uncertain world by sustaining investor confidence, enabling transparent price discovery and absorbing shocks, he said.

“Efficiency is the founda-

Key Points

» He went on to say that uncertainty is not an exception but a recurring feature in financial markets

» ‘The real test of a system is to check if it continues to function smoothly, fairly and efficiently in the face of challenges,’ he added

» ‘Volatility is a natural feature of markets. The real strength lies in the confidence that the system will function fairly, transparently and efficiently even during periods of stress’

tion of trust in the financial system. Without that trust, capital hesitates. Investment slows. And growth becomes more difficult to sustain,” he said.

The Indian capital markets have deepened and become more resilient over the last decade, Pandey said.

In an era when markets are reacting instantly to narratives, the key question policymakers and market participants are grappling with is how to ensure speed doesn’t compromise stability, Pandey said.

No fertiliser shortage, asserts government amid West Asia crisis

NEW DELHI: There is no shortage of fertilisers in the country in view of the West Asia conflict, the government said on Saturday, asserting that current stocks of urea and other crop nutrients remain “more than adequate.” External Affairs Ministry Spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said New Delhi’s partners have also assured it of uninterrupted fertiliser supplies.

“What I can tell you is that India has more than adequate stocks of fertilisers at this point of time, especially for the upcoming Kharif season,” he said. “Our stocks of urea are more than what they were at this point last year,” he said at an inter-ministerial media briefing on developments relating to the West Asia crisis.

Jaiswal said India’s DAP (Diammonium phosphate) stocks are double of what they

were in 2025, while the NPK (Nitrogen, Phosphorus and Potassium) stock position is similarly much higher today in comparison to last year.

“Observers and commentators would do well to look at the factual situation and not induce panic through uninformed speculation,” he said.

While DAP is the most widely used phosphorus fertiliser, NPK is suitable for all stages of plant growth.

“In so far as our domestic production of urea is concerned, our current production will be more than our nominal consumption, especially since the Rabi season is coming to an end,” the external affairs ministry spokesperson said.

“In addition, we had taken care to advance the scheduled annual maintenance of some of our plants, which means that

we are able to maximise production with available gas,” he said.

Jaiswal also mentioned the Department of Fertilisers (DoF) putting out global tenders “well in time” in anticipation of the current situation.

“These have received a very good response and we expect to receive the bulk of the quantities ordered from a variety of sources by end of March. The DoF has also decided to procure spot gas on a competitive basis and the first phase purchase will be by Tuesday,” he said.

“All our partners have assured us of uninterrupted supplies and we hope to attain and maintain comfortable fertiliser stocks by the time Kharif demand peaks by May 15,” he said. Jaiswal said the DoF is carefully tracking both global and domestic patterns and taking the requisite steps.

‘India-EFTA TEPA sets global benchmark with legally binding \$100 bn investment commitment’

NEW DELHI: For the first time ever, a Free Trade Agreement includes a legally binding commitment of \$100 billion in investments and the creation of one million jobs in India, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Saturday.

Speaking at a session commemorating the second anniversary of the India-European Free Trade Association (EFTA) Trade and Economic Partnership Agreement (TEPA), Goyal said the pact marks a new approach in India’s trade negotiations. “This has never happened before and reflects India’s new approach to trade negotiations,” he said.

The minister noted that TEPA marked the beginning of deeper economic engagement between India and Europe. Following the agreement, India also concluded trade pacts



with the United Kingdom and is advancing negotiations with the 27-nation European Union, expanding economic ties with several European economies.

Goyal said the comprehensive agreement promotes trade, technology, innovation and investment while opening significant opportunities in the services sector. At the same time, sensitive sectors such as dairy and genetically modified

products have been safeguarded to protect domestic interests.

The event was organised by ASSOCHAM to mark two years of the landmark agreement between India and the EFTA bloc comprising Switzerland, Norway, Iceland and Liechtenstein.

Chairing the session, Tribhuvan Darbari, Chairman of the BIMSTEC Business Council Secretariat (India) and Chair-

man of the national part of the SCO Business Council Secretariat, said trade agreements represent more than tariff reductions and market access. “They are the architecture of trust between nations and the institutionalisation of economic cooperation,” he added.

Darbari highlighted that India’s services sector, which contributes nearly 55 per cent to the country’s Gross Value Added, stands to benefit significantly from TEPA. The agreement provides market access across more than 100 services sub-sectors, including information technology, business services, education and audiovisual industries.

He also emphasised opportunities for tech collaboration with Switzerland & Norway could boost India’s access to European markets.

Akasa Air to levy fuel surcharge on flight tickets from March 15

NEW DELHI: Akasa Air will levy fuel surcharges ranging from Rs 199 to Rs 1,300 on domestic and international flight tickets from March 15 due to the spike in jet fuel prices amid the West Asia conflict.

Air India, Air India Express and IndiGo have started levying similar charges on domestic and international flight tickets.

In a statement on Saturday, Akasa Air said it would levy fuel surcharge for each flight and the quantum would vary based on the duration of the flight.

Government announces sanction of ₹100 crore Integrated Aqua Park Project in Anantnag, J&K

SRINAGAR: Union Minister for Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying Rajiv Ranjan Singh on Saturday announced a Rs 100 crore Integrated Aqua Park project for Anantnag district in Jammu and Kashmir and released model guidelines for the development of cold-water fisheries.

The announcement was made during the National Conference on Cold Water Fisheries organised by the Department of Fisheries at the Sher-e-Kashmir International Conference Centre in Srinagar.

The Integrated Aqua Park project is aimed at strengthening aquaculture infrastructure in the region, promoting cold-water fisheries, boosting



fish production and generating employment opportunities for local communities.

The event was attended by Jammu and Kashmir Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha, Chief Minister Omar Abdullah, Minister of State for Fish-

eries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying S. P. Singh Baghel, and J&K Agriculture Production Minister Javid Ahmad Dar, among others.

During the programme, Singh, along with the Lieutenant Governor and the Chief

Minister, presented awards to best fisheries cooperative societies, progressive fish farmers, fisheries start-ups and beneficiaries of government schemes. Refrigerated vehicles were also distributed to stakeholders from across Jammu and Kashmir to strengthen the fisheries value chain.

The dignitaries also jointly released the “Model Guidelines for Reservoir Fisheries and Aquaculture Management”. The guidelines provide a framework for scientific seed stocking, cage and pen-based aquaculture, leasing systems, biodiversity conservation, value-chain development and monitoring mechanisms to support sustainable fisheries growth.

NCHF BOARD MEETING



The meeting of the Board of Directors of the National Cooperative Housing Federation of India (NCHF) was held on Saturday at its headquarters in New Delhi. This was the last meeting of the present Board before the completion of its tenure. The process of constituting a new Board will begin in April. During the meeting, Asis Chakraborty, Chairman of West Bengal State Cooperative Housing Federation Ltd. (WBHousfed), felicitated Bijoy Singh (MLC-Bihar), Chairman of NCHF, in recognition of his successful leadership and tenure. Various organizational matters were also discussed in the meeting.

HFCL bags ₹10,159 cr order from foreign firm for supplying optical fibre cable

NEW DELHI: Homegrown telecom gear maker HFCL has bagged a mega deal of around Rs 10,159 crore from a global multinational corporation for supplying optical fibre cable, the company said on Friday. The deal is spread over five years from 2026 to December, 2030.

“The company has entered into a five-year supply agreement with a customer for the supply of high-quality, high-fibre-count optical fiber cables, through its overseas wholly

owned subsidiary. The total potential value of the contract is estimated at around \$1.10 billion equivalent to about Rs 10,159 crore based on prevailing selling prices of OFC products being supplied,” it said.

HFCL did not disclose the name of the customer in the filing. “This agreement marks a significant milestone, being the first instance in the company’s history of entering into a long-term, multi-year OFC supply arrangement of this nature,” the

filing said. Under the contract, HFCL will supply OFC as per customer specifications.

“Given that only a limited number of manufacturers globally possess the requisite technology depth, manufacturing precision, and scale required for such complex OFC products, this engagement materially strengthens the company’s competitive positioning and reinforces its long-term growth outlook in the global OFC market,” the filing said.

SISA recognised as PCI lab for payment device security tests

The certification makes SISA India’s first PCI recognised lab to conduct full security evaluations

BENGALURU: Cybersecurity firm SISA on Saturday said it has been recognised as a laboratory by the PCI Security Standards Council to conduct security evaluations of payment acceptance devices and solutions.

PCI-recognised laboratories are authorised to assess payment devices using PCI PIN Transaction Security (PTS) standards, including Hardware Security Modules (HSM) and Point of

CLOSER LOOK

» PCI-recognised laboratories are authorised to assess payment devices using PCI PTS standards, including Hardware Security Modules & Point of Interaction

» SISA now joins a select group of global laboratories that validate whether payment devices and solutions meet strict requirements for protecting cardholder data

Interaction (POI) devices. Some labs are also approved to test solutions under standards such

as Mobile Payments on COTS (MPoC), Software-based PIN Entry on COTS (SPoC), Con-

tactless Payments on COTS (CPoC) and PCI 3DS Software Development Kits (SDK).

With the recognition, SISA joins a select group of global laboratories that validate whether payment devices and solutions meet strict requirements for protecting cardholder data. The certification also makes SISA the first laboratory in India authorised to conduct full security evaluations under the PCI MPoC standard.

This enables the company to support SoftPOS and mobile payment solution providers in securing formal validation for applications running on commercial off-the-shelf smartphones and tablets.

SISA Founder and CEO Dharshan Shanthamurthy said the recognition would help strengthen security for emerging tap-to-phone and mobile payment acceptance solutions.

CM Gupta unveils major infra push aimed at revamping roads, drainage

Launches remodelling of stormwater drain on Haiderpur Main Road

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday inaugurated a series of infrastructure development projects aimed at improving drainage, road connectivity and traffic flow in the national capital.

To address the problem of waterlogging permanently, strengthening the drainage system is as important as improving roads, she said while interacting with officials.

During the visit, Gupta launched the remodelling of a stormwater drain on Haiderpur Main Road, stretching from the local bus stand to DA Block.

“The project is being implemented under the New Master Drain Plan 2025 and will involve the construction of reinforced cement concrete (RCC) drains to strengthen the drainage network,” Gupta said. She also reviewed the progress of several other drainage and infrastructure projects underway in the area, including

PNG supply to hospitals safe, claims IGL

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In response to recent media reports, Indraprastha Gas Limited has clarified that piped natural gas (PNG) supply to hospitals and other essential services remains stable and uninterrupted.

The company issued the statement following concerns raised after Qatar declared force majeure on 3 March, which had initially prompted warnings about potential disruptions. IGL immediately arranged alternative supplies, and there is currently no shortage of natural gas in the country. IGL emphasized that it has prioritized supply to critical institutions, including hospitals and healthcare facilities, ensuring that medical operations continue without interruption. The company also confirmed that industrial and commercial consumers are receiving regulated supplies according to existing protocols. The company’s teams are continuously monitoring the situation and coordinating with upstream suppliers to maintain seamless delivery to all priority consumers.

IGL urged customers not to rely on speculative reports and to contact the company directly for any clarifications or support, reaffirming its commitment.



Rekha Gupta during the inauguration of ‘Ayushman Arogya Mandir’, in Shalimar Bagh, on Saturday

ing works on Road No 319, Road No 320, Chaudhary Mehr Chand Marg, Swami Shradhdhanand Saraswati Marg and the road under bridge at RUB Shalimar Bagh.

In a move aimed at easing congestion, Gupta also launched the construction of a slip road at Shalimar Chowk

along with a new U-turn facility. “These measures will help streamline traffic movement and ensure smoother and safer travel for residents and commuters,” she said.

The CM also inaugurated an Ayushman Arogya Mandir at Sahipur village chaupal, aimed at improving access to

primary healthcare services for local residents. Later, Gupta conducted a surprise inspection of the ongoing road widening and drainage improvement works at Singapur Labour Chowk. She directed officials to maintain quality, transparency and ensure timely completion of the projects.

CM backs artists

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday attended the Tribes Arts Festival-2026 and said the capital’s doors are open for artists and cultural practitioners who boost the inclusive character of the city. The 12-day Tribes Art Fest organised by the Ministry of Tribal Affairs in collaboration with FICCI and the National Gallery of Modern Art concluded with a valedictory ceremony at the Travancore Palace.

“Such initiatives play an important role in highlighting the vibrant traditions. The national capital will always welcome artists and cultural practitioners who enrich Delhi with the spirit of inclusivity,” she said.

Govt prepares ‘Water Master Plan’, to rope in pvt players for upgrade



Waterlogging in the city is a common sight in the monsoon

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government is preparing a comprehensive Water Master Plan, with a provision to rope in private players, to relieve the city residents of their woes, Water Minister Parvash Sahib Singh said on Saturday.

Under the plan, a study of the existing infrastructure and the future expansion will be undertaken, keeping in mind the city’s increasing population.

“There is a need for a holistic approach towards fixing the water sector challenges that we face, so for the first time a Water Master Plan will be presented. For this we have hired a consultant company which is studying all the major aspects including sources of water, requirements in future, water pipelines maintenance and other things,” Singh said.

Another aspect of the plan would be decentralisation and privatisation of the Delhi Jal Board (DJB) distribution network.

“Within the next one year we will float tenders inviting big private players for management of each of DJB’s existing eight Command Centres. In future these companies will be given each of the zones and they will be responsible for managing all the major operations in those areas,” the minister said, according to a statement.

Under the plan, each of the companies will be tasked with the job of repairing and replacing old water pipes, billing and revenue collection, and regular water supply.

Tenders will be floated soon for East, North-East, West and South-West zones.

SIS Council backs JNUSU protest

NEW DELHI: The Students’ Council of the School of International Studies (SIS) at Jawaharlal Nehru University has expressed strong support for the ongoing movement led by the Jawaharlal Nehru University Students’ Union (JNUSU), alleging administrative repression and demanding the removal of the university’s Vice-Chancellor.

In a statement issued on Friday, the SIS Council said students had come together to defend their right to a democratic campus following the rustication of JNUSU office-bearers and alleged casteist remarks made by the Vice-Chancellor last month. The council noted that a General Body Meeting resolved to stand in solidarity with union members and students facing administrative action and to intensify the ongoing protest.

Referring to a recent referendum conducted by the JNUSU, the council claimed that 2,181 students expressed no confidence in the continuation of the Vice-Chancellor’s tenure. It urged the administration to take note of the sentiment among students and respond to their concerns.

PROJECT AIMS TO MODERNISE PUMPING INFRA MCD okays STP project; 105 workers regularised

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The General House of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) approved several proposals aimed at improving civic infrastructure, environmental sustainability and employee welfare, Mayor Raja Iqbal Singh said.

Addressing the media, the Mayor stated that the House cleared a proposal for remodeling an existing pump house for sludge drainage and constructing a Sewage Treatment Plant (STP) to supply treated water



to municipal parks in Sunder Nagri, Shastri Park, IP Extension, Laxmi Nagar and adjoining areas. The project aims to modernise pumping infrastructure and promote water conservation by utilising treated wastewater for horticulture in nearby parks.

Singh said the initiative would support sustainable urban development while strengthening the city’s green cover. “Such projects will help maintain ecological balance while ensuring better utilisation of treated wastewater,” he added.

The House also approved a proposal to allow NGOs, Resident Welfare Societies and self-help groups to adopt, develop and maintain cremation grounds, burial grounds and cemeteries under the corporation’s jurisdiction. According to the Mayor, 24 organisations have

been selected for the initiative.

In addition, two NGOs have been recommended to undertake a pilot project using 100% ‘Upla’ (cow dung cakes) for cremation at the Green Park crematorium ground in the South Zone and the Dwarka Sector-24 crematorium ground in the Najafgarh Zone, in an effort to promote environmentally sustainable practices and reduce dependence on firewood.

The Mayor further announced that the services of 105 Safai Karamcharis have been regularised.

Anti-encroachment drive carried out in Uttam Nagar: MCD

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) carried out an anti-encroachment drive in B-Block in JJ Colony, Hast-sal, Uttam Nagar on Saturday, clearing temporary structures outside shops and reclaiming road space meant for pedestrians and vehicles. Officials said unauthorised thadas (raised platform), stairs and temporary sheds in front of around 70 shops were removed during the operation, freeing nearly 380 metres (about 760 square metres) of public road that had been encroached.

The action is part of an ongoing enforcement campaign across the West Zone.

Similar drives were conducted at Vishnu Garden on March 11, Milan Market in Subhash Nagar on March 12, and Pankha Road on March 13. Civic officials said the latest drive was aimed at restoring public spaces and ensuring smoother movement for pedestrians and traffic. The operation was carried out with the assistance of the Delhi Police.

Earlier, it was reported that corporation had sealed

Highlights

- » Similar drives were conducted at Vishnu Garden on March 11, Milan Market in Subhash Nagar on March 12, and Pankha Road on March 13
- » Police personnel were deployed to maintain law and order during the exercise

some shops. However, the MCD later confirmed that no such action was taken.

MCD teams, assisted by the Delhi Police, launched the action amid tight security arrangements, deploying bulldozers to remove alleged illegal structures of shops operating in violation of civic norms.

The drive targeted a row of eateries built outside the Uttam Nagar police station premises. The action comes days after a 26-year-old man named Tarun was killed in a clash that broke out between his family and neighbours in the JJ Colony.

MCD students shine at ‘Purple Fest’

NEW DELHI: Students with disabilities from schools run by the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) participated in the annual Purple Fest held at the picturesque Amrit Udyan within the premises of Rashtrapati Bhavan, marking their first-ever participation in the event.

A total of 11 students from MCD schools took part in the festival, which celebrates inclusivity and provides a platform for persons with disabilities to showcase their talent. Two students presented a dance performance during the programme, while nine others participated in a fancy dress competition, reflecting enthusiasm and creativity. The festival also provided the students with an opportunity to explore the iconic Amrit Udyan, one of the most visited gardens in the Presidential Estate. International para-athlete Vikas Dagar attended the event.



Truck hits scooty on ITO flyover; 1 dead, 2 hurt; all 3 helmetless

NEW DELHI: A 20-year-old man was killed, and two others were injured after a truck allegedly struck the scooter they were riding on the ITO flyover in central Delhi, police said on Saturday. The incident

occurred around 1.30 am during the intervening night of March 11 and 12, when the three were returning home after a night out, they said.

Following the accident, police received information

about the road incident and the injured individuals were transported to Lok Nayak Hospital.

At the hospital, Karan (20), a resident of Faridabad, was declared dead by doctors. The other two occupants

of the scooter — Yash Kapoor (20), also from Faridabad, and Sandeep Bhatia (44) — sustained injuries and are currently undergoing treatment, police said, adding that none were wearing helmets.

LPG woes bite city’s restaurants

Eateries cut menus; pause large bookings, corporate gatherings

NEW DELHI: Large corporate gatherings and group parties are now taking a backseat in restaurant calendars across the capital, as eateries scale back menus and bookings amid an LPG supply crunch, with concerns over shrinking cooking gas stocks growing after military escalations in West Asia.

Restaurant owners, particularly in Connaught Place, one of the city’s busiest dining hubs, said that preparing food for large tables requires significant gas usage, prompting many establishments to temporarily halt big party bookings while focusing on regular diners.

Paramjeet Kaur, owner of Flavours of China, said the restaurant has scaled back certain offerings and limited group bookings in order to manage LPG consumption.

“We have had to make a few adjustments to manage the

Police boost LPG security

NEW DELHI: Amid prevailing concerns over irregular LPG supply, the Delhi Police has intensified surveillance at LPG godowns and distribution points across the city.

Officers have been deployed in plain clothes and are holding meetings with gas distributors, warning of strict legal action against anyone involved in black marketing.

This action comes a day after the cancellation of routine leave for police personnel



nel to maintain law and order amid rising anxiety among households and businesses regarding the availability of cooking gas.

Kaur added that the restaurant has also temporarily stopped hosting large gatherings to conserve fuel.

A manager at Amaltas, a restaurant in Greater Kailash, said the establishment has also been cautious about accepting

large bookings in the current situation.

“With the uncertainty around LPG availability, we are being careful about taking big table reservations or corporate events. Preparing food for large groups requires continuous gas usage, so we are prioritising regular diners and smaller tables for now,” the manager said.

Inder, owner of Minar restaurant in Connaught Place, said his establishment has also decided to avoid large-scale bookings until the LPG supply situation stabilises.

“At the moment, we are not taking corporate meetings or big events because managing such gatherings requires extensive cooking, and that means higher LPG consumption. Given the uncertainty around supply, it becomes difficult to plan for large bookings,” he said.

Delhi State Legal Services Authority

In coordination with

DELHI TRAFFIC POLICE

Is organising

National Lok Adalat

at seven court complexes on 22nd March, 2026

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Dwarka

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- All the **Notices/Challans** are to be downloaded from Delhi Traffic Police Website i.e **https://traffic.delhipolice.gov.in/lokadalat** or by **scanning the QR Code**.
- It is mandatory to **carry a printout of the Notice/ Challan**, as no printing facility will be available at the court complexes.

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BJP TO GO SOLO IN STATE-POLLS

Punjab: Shah promises anti-conversion law, end to drug menace

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MOGA: Union Home minister Amit Shah on Saturday asserted that the BJP will fight the 2027 polls on its own with the aim to form its government in Punjab, where it had only been a junior partner to SAD, and promised to bring an anti-conversion law and end the drug menace in the state, urging voters to give the party one opportunity to bring change.

Sounding the poll bugle at a “Badlav” (change) rally in Moga, the senior BJP leader said that the people of the state have given many chances to Congress, Akalis and Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), but these parties could not deliver.

“Today, Punjab has been destroyed due to debt, drugs, religious conversions, corruption and terror of gangsters,” Shah said and asserted that only the BJP and Prime Minister Narendra Modi can rid the state of its problems.

Launching a stinging broadside against the Bhagwant Mann government over the drug menace and law and order issues, he promised that the drug trade would be rooted out in just two years if the BJP comes to power in 2027.

Accusing the Mann government of being steeped in corruption, Shah alleged that it has become an “ATM” for AAP supremo Arvind Kejriwal.

Shah also vowed to bring a law to check illegal religious conversions in Punjab if the BJP forms the government in the 2027 Assembly polls, even as he asserted that peace and development in Punjab were



A Border Security Force (BSF) personnel stands guard along the Srinagar-Leh National highway, in Ganderbal district

PTI

Highlights

» Shah alleged that it has become an “ATM” for AAP supremo Arvind Kejriwal

» Shah said that Punjab does not need a CM to make people laugh but one who can govern the state well

not possible without Hindu-Sikh unity, and “only under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, this unity is possible”.

Targeting Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann, who was a comic actor before entering politics, Shah said that Punjab does not need a CM to make people laugh but one who can govern the state well.

Citing a report, Shah said 45 per cent of the total drug

trade in the country is in Punjab only.

“We scrapped Article 370 in J&K. Today, Naxalism is on the verge of its end,” he said, adding that terrorism is also counting its last breaths.

Shah, who was wearing a saffron turban, said if anybody can free Punjab from drugs and other problems, it is only Narendra Modi and the BJP.

“AAP doesn’t have the gumption to end the drug menace; Congress and Akalis have already failed. If there is anyone who can rid the state of the drug menace, it is only Narendra Modi and the BJP,” Shah said.

Addressing the rally, Shah said that the polls are going to take place in 2027, and from Moga, the BJP, in a way, has launched its poll campaign. “I have come to appeal to people of Punjab,” the Union minister said, seeking support for his party.

Resign if you don’t feel competent enough: HC to Sambhal SP and DM on limiting number of people in mosque

OUR CORRESPONDENT

PRAYAGRAJ: Rejecting an order of the Uttar Pradesh government restricting the number of people offering prayers at a mosque in Sambhal district due to law and order issues, the Allahabad High Court has said the Superintendent of Police and Collector should either resign or seek transfer if they feel they are not competent enough to enforce rule of law.

A bench of justices Atul Sreedharan and Siddharth Nandan observed, “It is duty of the State to ensure that every community is able to offer worship peacefully in

Key Points

» ‘It is duty of the State to ensure that every community is able to offer worship peacefully in the designated place of worship’

» The court was hearing a petition filed by Munazir Khan of Sambhal alleging that he was prevented from conducting prayers during Ramzan on Gata No.291

the designated place of worship and if it is a private property as already been held by the court earlier to perform worship without any permission from the State.”

The court was hearing a petition filed by Munazir Khan of Sambhal alleging that he was prevented

from conducting prayers during Ramzan on Gata No.291, where according to the petitioner, the mosque exists.

“This court has already settled that it is only where prayers or religious functions have to be held on public land or spill over the public prop-

erty that the involvement of the state is essential and permission must be sought,” the court said in its order dated February 27.

The state has disputed the ownership of Gata No.291 by saying that this is reflected in the names of Mohan Singh and Bhooraj Singh, both sons of Sukhi Singh, in the revenue records.

However, permission was granted only to the extent of 20 worshippers who may offer namaz, whereas the petitioner says a larger number of people may come for prayers as it is the month of Ramzan.

Counsel for the State said that on account of per-

ceived law and order situation, such an order restricting number of worshippers was passed.

After hearing counsels for the parties, the court said, “It is the duty of the State to ensure that the rule of law prevails under every circumstance. If the local authorities i.e. Superintendent of Police and Collector feel that the law and order situation could arise because of which they want to limit the number of worshippers within the premises, they should either resign from their post or seek transfer outside Sambhal.”

The court fixed March 16 for the next hearing.

Jharkhand: Five killed, 14 injured in separate road accidents

RANCHI/HAZARIBAG: Five people were killed and 14 others injured in two separate road accidents in Ranchi and Hazaribag districts of Jharkhand on Saturday, police said.

In Ranchi district, two persons died on the spot after a speeding four-wheeler ran over the crowd at a local fair in Mankidhipa under the Tatisilway Police Station limits.

Praveen Pushkar, SP (Rural), said, “Two persons were killed, and seven others sustained critical injuries in this accident. The injured have been rushed to hospital for treatment. The car has been seized, while the driver of the vehicle fled the scene.”

Hanse Oraon, the officer in-charge of Tatisilway police station, said that the deceased have been identified as Bhola Sharma (65) and Rima Kumari (25).

In Hazaribag district three persons were killed after a

truck rammed into multiple vehicles.

The accident took place near Charhi Chowk on National Highway 33 on the Ranchi–Hazaribag road when the driver lost control of the truck, and it collided with three vehicles, including a bus, they said.

“Two persons died on the spot, while the third succumbed to injuries during treatment. Seven people, who were passengers of the bus, sustained critical injuries and are undergoing treatment at Sheikh Bhikhari Medical College and Hospital,” said Kundan Kant Vimal, officer-in-charge of Charhi police station.

In protest, locals blocked the route for more than five hours, demanding compensation for the families of the deceased and the arrest of the truck driver, Bishnugarh SDPO BN Prasad said.

AGENCIES

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India threads...

touch and coordinate with all the concerned countries to ensure a safe and unimpeded transit for them in our effort to ensure our energy security,” MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said at the briefing.

Sinha said in all 28 Indian flags vessels were stuck - 24 on the west of the Strait of Hormuz and four on the east.

Amid a growing domestic gas supply crunch triggered by global tensions in the aftermath of West Asia conflict, disruptions in cooking gas availability are being reported across several parts of Asia, with the ripple effects being felt in India as well.

Restaurants, hotels, and households in many cities, towns, and rural areas are struggling to secure regular LPG supplies. Meanwhile, commercial LPG cylinder distribution has begun in 29 states and Union Territories, while authorities have stepped up raids across the country to curb hoarding and black-marketing, a senior oil ministry official said.

Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary in the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, said panic booking continues to rise despite the fact that there are enough stocks available to meet domestic household requirements of cooking gas LPG.

India, she said, has adequate crude oil inventories, and domestic refineries are operating at full capacity, ensuring sufficient availability of petrol and diesel across the country.

Sharma said domestic LPG supply is being prioritised even as the government continues to closely monitor the situation amid the prevailing geopolitical developments that hampered energy supplies from the Gulf countries.

“The situation is a matter of concern for all of us, but we are ensuring that household consumers do not face inconvenience. Domestic consumers have been prioritized, and LPG cylinder supply is being ensured for them,” she said.

However, LPG refill bookings have surged sharply due to panic buying by consumers. “Yesterday, the number of bookings was about 75 lakh, and it has now increased to around 88 lakh. This is nothing but panic booking,” she said, urging consumers to book cylinders only when required.

Pre-war, daily bookings totalled around 55 lakh and oil marketing companies delivered 50 lakh cylinders per day. While the cylinder deliveries remain the same, bookings have surged.

She also clarified that booking restrictions are linked to the time gap between two deliveries. “In urban areas, there is a minimum gap of 25 days between the last delivery and the next booking, while in rural areas the gap is 45 days. If consumers try to book before this window, the booking will not take place,” she said.

To ease supply pressure, the government has ramped up domestic LPG production from 10 per cent to 31 per cent as of now.

The official added that state-run GAIL has met city gas distribution (CGD) operators and asked them to provide piped natural gas (PNG) connections to commercial consumers facing LPG supply constraints. Consumers who can

easily shift from LPG to PNG - both domestic and commercial - are being encouraged, she said.

Joint teams in Maharashtra and Rajasthan have carried out inspections, while in Uttar Pradesh, authorities conducted surprise checks at around 1,400 locations. People continue to queue up at the gas agencies in different states, including the national Capital, as they struggle to get a refill.

The Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas said that it has barred consumers with piped natural gas connections from retaining, obtaining or refilling domestic LPG cylinders under an amended supply order.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

Climate crusader...

The decision, the Centre said, was to foster an environment of peace and mutual trust in Ladakh to facilitate constructive dialogue with all stakeholders. In its official statement, the government reiterated its commitment to foster an environment of peace, stability and mutual trust in Ladakh to facilitate constructive and meaningful dialogue with all stakeholders.

“In furtherance of this objective, and after due consideration, the Government has decided to revoke the detention of Sonam Wangchuk with immediate effect by exercising the powers available under the National Security Act,” it said.

Reiterating its “commitment” to provide all necessary safeguards for Ladakh, the government expressed hope that the issues concerning the region will be resolved through constructive engagement and dialogue, including through the “mechanism of the High-Powered Committee”, constituted to address the concerns of the people of Ladakh, and other appropriate platforms.

Two days ago, Wangchuk had written on X that a just future for Ladakh would require sincere dialogue. “I have not stepped away from activism. My commitment to Ladakh remains unchanged... But activism must serve a larger purpose: a just, lasting future for Ladakh. It will require clarity, unity, and sincere dialogue.

“Our struggle has always been for Ladakh’s protection, dignity, and long-term well-being and shall continue to be!” he had said.

Vivek Tankha, Congress leader and lawyer for Wangchuk, asserted that he is a nationalist and his role will be crucial for Ladakh’s security and stability. Newly sworn-in Ladakh Lt. Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena welcomed the Centre’s decision, calling it a “positive step”, but underlined that “there is no place for agitation, bandhs, or violence in Ladakh. Such actions do not contribute to meaningful progress.”

“Instead, the path of cooperation and peaceful engagement should be followed to achieve lasting solutions,” he said in a statement issued by Lok Bhavan.

The Leh Apex Body (LAB) and the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA), which are spearheading the agitation over demands for statehood for Ladakh and its inclusion under the Sixth Schedule of the Constitution, termed the release a “big victory” for the people of Ladakh, saying it vindicated their stand on his innocence and removed the anti-national blot on the region.

The LAB and KDA remain engaged in talks with the Ministry of Home Affairs over their key demands of statehood and Sixth Schedule inclusion, issues that have simmered since the region

was carved out of Jammu and Kashmir as a Union Territory in 2019.

The last meeting of the high-powered committee chaired by Minister of State for Home Affairs Nityanand Rai took place on February 4, where both bodies demanded the release of Wangchuk, among other demands.

“This is not just about Wangchuk but about the whole of Ladakh. We had maintained from the start that the allegations against him, including the anti-national charge, were baseless. Today, Ladakh stands vindicated,” LAB Co-Chairman Chering Dorje said in Leh. He said the movement for Ladakh’s political demands would continue despite the release.

Calling the development a major relief, he said the people of Ladakh felt hurt by the anti-national allegations made against them. “We are among the most nationalist people in the country, yet we were branded anti-national for the first time. It was a serious blot on Ladakh.

Welcoming the revocation of the NSA against Wangchuk, Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah called for the release of those arrested in the valley during the recent anti-US and anti-Israel protests.

Abdullah noted that just like Wangchuk’s case, those facing minor charges or those who have spent longer in jail than their sentence would otherwise be should be released as well.

“We welcome the release of Sonam Wangchuk. But others also need to be released, and the government should also take back the cases filed against people who participated in the protests,” Ladakh MP Mohamad Hanifa said. He said that the protest was a constitutional right and urged the government to pursue dialogue.

PDP president Mehbooba Mufti said the stringent law should never have been invoked against the environmentalist.

Jammu and Kashmir Congress also welcomed the release of the innovator activist and questioned the circumstances that led to his detention for more than six months “without clear justification”.

Trump calls world...

control tower and an offshore oil company’s helicopter hangar.

A missile struck a helipad inside the US Embassy compound in Baghdad, two Iraqi security officials said. Associated Press footage showed a column of smoke rising Saturday morning over the embassy compound.

The sprawling embassy complex, one of the largest US diplomatic facilities in the world, has been repeatedly targeted by rockets and drones fired by Iran-aligned militias.

Israel earlier announced another wave of strikes in Iran targeting infrastructure, and said its air force had hit more than 200 targets in the last 24 hours, including missile launchers, defence systems and weapons production sites.

In Washington, US Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth said that over 15,000 enemy targets have been struck — more than 1,000 a day since the war began.

Roughly 2,500 Marines and at least one amphibious assault ship are headed for the Middle East, a US official told The Associated Press.

The official, who spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive military plans, said

elements from the 31st Marine Expeditionary Unit and the amphibious assault ship USS Tripoli have been ordered to the Middle East. The move marks a major addition of troops to the region.

Meanwhile, the humanitarian crisis in Lebanon deepened, with nearly 800 people killed and 850,000 displaced as Israel launched waves of strikes against Iran-backed Hezbollah militants and warned there would be no let-up.

Govt easing war...

leaving them mired in violence and backwardness.

“Just as the Congress left the Northeast on its own, in a similar way, it played a major role in weakening the Barak Valley. When India became Independent, Congress allowed a border to be drawn that cut off Barak Valley’s access to the sea,” he alleged. “Barak Valley, once known as an industrial centre, was stripped of its very strength. For decades after Independence, Congress governments remained in power, yet the region saw little development. Today, the BJP government is working to change that,” he added.

Modi said connectivity is being developed in the Barak Valley to link it to other parts of the Northeast and West Bengal.

“It will be developed as a big logistics and trade hub of the region,” he said, noting that Barak Valley is also at the centre of the government’s Act East Policy and will be a bridge connecting India with Southeast Asia.

The PM alleged that Congress misguided Assam’s youth into paths of violence and terrorism, while the BJP has ensured the state becomes a place of unlimited opportunities where they can reach for the sky. “Where Congress stops thinking, we start working,” he said, noting that the BJP’s mantra is to give priority to those left behind in development. “Assam’s youth have immense opportunities in the semiconductor and technology sectors. The current era of peace and progress has been achieved through immense sacrifices, which must be protected from regressive forces,” he said.

Modi said education, skill development, and healthcare have become the primary pillars of the government’s development thrust.

Assam is rapidly emerging as a health hub, with AIIMS and cancer hospitals now forming a strong network, he said. The PM said that during the Congress rule, the border villages were considered the “last villages”, but his government views them as the nation’s “first villages”.

“The second phase of the Vibrant Village Program has begun from the Cachar district and is already bringing visible improvements to border areas. The historical neglect of these areas is now being replaced by proactive development and strategic focus,” he said.

The PM said the state government has performed a “historical duty” by granting land rights to thousands of families of tea garden workers.

“Granting of land rights is not only a legal security that ensures dignity, but will now also allow these families to access central schemes for housing, electricity, and water,” he said.

Referring to former PM Manmohan Singh, Modi said he represented Assam for 10 years but did not give a single paise to the farmers of the state, whereas the BJP has given them more than Rs 20,000 crore.

'NEW CHAPTER IS BEING WRITTEN FOR BENGAL'

PM unveils connectivity projects worth Rs 18,680 cr in West Bengal

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: Prime Minister Narendra Modi unveiled connectivity projects valued at Rs 18,680 crore in West Bengal on Saturday, and said a new chapter of India's development was being written from the state.

The PM asserted that these projects will give new momentum to West Bengal and eastern India, boosting business and enterprise.

"A new chapter is being written for West Bengal and eastern India's development from Kolkata.... Lives of lakhs of people will be eased; they will get new opportunities," Modi said after inaugurating and laying the foundation stone for the projects at a programme here.

He said these projects will further strengthen eastern India's logistics system.

"These new projects related to roads, rail and ports are open-



Prime Minister Narendra Modi addresses the gathering during a rally, at Brigade Parade Ground in Kolkata

PTI

ing new vistas for Bengal's modern future," he said.

The PM said that these projects will benefit everyone, including farmers, traders, entrepreneurs and students.

"New opportunities will be created in the tourism sector also," he said, adding that local enterprise and services will get a boost from the projects.

"We are determined to ensure that Bengal, which once showed the way to the rest of India, will once again become a developed state and regain its glory," he said.

Modi said that strong connectivity and modern infrastructure will become the foundation of a developed Bengal.

Highlights

» The PM asserted that these projects will give new momentum to West Bengal and eastern India, boosting business and enterprise

» The PM said that these projects will benefit everyone, including farmers, traders, entrepreneurs and students

nearly seven to eight hours.

The road, which is part of the economic corridor between Kharagpur and Siliguri, will pass through Paschim Medinipur, Bankura, Hooghly, Purba Bardhaman, Birbhum and Murshidabad districts, officials said.

The corridor will integrate key national highways, including NH-16, NH-19, NH-14 and NH-12, thereby strengthening multi-corridor connectivity, they said.

The PM also laid the foundation stone for the construction of a 5.6-km-long four-lane Dubrajpur Bypass and additional four-lane major bridges over the Kangshabati and Shilabati rivers on NH-14.

He inaugurated sections of NH-19 and NH-114, which will enhance road safety, reduce travel time, ease congestion and pollution, improve regional connectivity, and boost tourism and economic growth in the region.

'Govt prepared to sacrifice India's agriculture for its own interest'

The government also admitted to pressuring states to discontinue MSP bonuses, says LoP in Lok Sabha

OUR CORRESPONDENT



Rahul Gandhi

NEW DELHI: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi alleged on Saturday that the BJP-led government has not honoured its promises made to farmers and is prepared to sacrifice India's agriculture for its own interest.

In a Facebook post, the leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha shared a question he asked in the House recently regarding announcing a minimum support price for crops and whether the trade agreement with the United States would change the Narendra Modi government's existing MSP policy.

"In the Lok Sabha, I asked a direct question to the government: Why has the promise of a statutory MSP -- calculated at C2+50 per cent -- made to farmers in 2021, not yet been implemented?"

"Evading a direct response,

the government merely reiterated its existing MSP policy. The government also admitted to pressuring states to discontinue MSP bonuses -- a move it sought to justify, without any logical basis, in the name of 'national priorities'," Gandhi said in his post in Hindi.

He said another critical question is whether the trade agreement with the US speaks of reducing "non-trade barriers".

"Does this imply an intent to undermine the MSP mechanism and government procurement?" the Congress

Another critical question is whether the trade agreement with the US speaks of reducing "non-trade barriers", said Gandhi

leader asked.

"The government is evading this question as well," he claimed.

"The Modi government not only refuses to honour the promises made to farmers, but it is also prepared to sacrifice Indian agriculture for the sake of its own interest," Gandhi alleged in his post.

"We will continue to raise our voices -- both inside and outside Parliament -- to defend farmers' rights and protect the MSP," the Congress leader asserted.

'Oppn ruled for many years, but it only indulged in votebank politics'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KAITHAL: Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Saturday took a dig at the opposition parties, saying they ruled the country for many years, but they only indulged in appeasement and votebank politics.

He said that after Independence, the Opposition ruled the country for several years.

"But why did they not think about your 'astha' (belief)? Because they did not have time, and only indulged in appeasement and votebank....," Adityanath said while addressing a gathering of saints in Haryana's Kaithal district.

Referring to the construction of Lord Ram's temple in

'After Independence, be it the Kashmir problem or the Naxal problem, these issues have been created by these very people'

Ayodhya, he said it became possible when the BJP governments came to power both at the Centre and in UP.

Citing Kashi Vishwanath and other temples, where major reconstruction work has been carried out in recent years, he said this becomes possible when the government

thinks about it.

"When anti-Sanatan governments come to power, they will engage in appeasement. After Independence, be it the Kashmir problem or the Naxal problem, these issues have been created by these very people - those who divided the country in the name of appeasement," he said.

He said the people who engage in anti-Sanatan conduct and work to weaken India, will no longer be accepted by the people of India now.

He said that if we strengthen the Sanatan Dharma in the country, our nation will become stronger. If the Sanatan Dharma is strong, then the nation will also be strong, he said.

Progressive Punjab Investors Summit received overwhelming support: CM Mann

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Saturday strongly criticised Union Home minister Amit Shah for failing to address Punjab's key concerns during his visit to the state, stating that people had expected announcements on MSP, farm loan waiver and a special package but were left disappointed.

The Chief Minister said the BJP-led Centre has consistently discriminated against Punjab by withholding its rightful funds, ignoring farmers' demands and failing to act on major drug seizures outside the state, while attempting to defame Punjab. The Chief Minister asserted

Closer Look

» 'BJP-led Centre has consistently discriminated against Punjab by withholding its rightful funds, ignoring farmers' demands', said CM

» 'Punjab government is taking decisive steps to curb drugs, strengthen the economy and attract investment'

that despite such challenges, the Punjab government is taking decisive steps to curb drugs, strengthen the economy and attract investment, adding that the Progressive Punjab Investors Summit has received overwhelming support from industry leaders exploring new opportunities in the state.

Interacting with the media on Saturday on the sidelines of the Progressive Punjab Inves-

tors Summit, CM Mann stated that farmers and citizens of Punjab had hoped for concrete decisions addressing their concerns.

"We expected Amit Shah to speak about MSP, loan waiver or special package for Punjab, but he left after merely abusing Punjabis," stated Mann. He added that people of Punjab were expecting big announcements such as a legal guaran-

tee of MSP for crops, waiver of farm loans and other measures for farmers.

The CM also criticised the Centre for withholding Punjab's rightful funds. "The Modi government has withheld Punjab's RDF and GST funds, and has still not released ₹1,600 crore flood relief compensation," stated CM Mann.

He said that despite tall claims made by Prime Minister Narendra Modi regarding ₹1,600 crore in flood relief, Punjab had not received even ₹16 from that announcement. He added that during the devastating floods, leaders from the Centre only visited Punjab for what he termed "disaster tourism."

CM Sai launches 'Gaudham Yojana': A new boost to cattle conservation

RAIPUR: Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai launched the 'Gaudham Yojana' by inaugurating a Gaudham facility at Lakhasar village in Takhatpur development block of Bilaspur district on March 14, marking a significant step towards strengthening cattle conservation in Chhattisgarh.

On the occasion, the Chief Minister worshipped Gau Mata and inspected the Gaudham premises to review its arrangements and facilities.

During the visit, Chief Minister Sai inspected the arrangements made for the care of stray and destitute cattle, including fodder supply, drinking water facilities and veterinary care.

He also reviewed the graz-



Vishnu Deo Sai

ing land developed for the animals. It is noteworthy that the Gaudham in Lakhasar village has been developed over nearly 25 acres of land, of which 19 acres have been dedicated to the cultivation of green fodder for cattle. The Gaudham is being managed by the Kamdhenu Gausala Samiti.

Addressing the gathering,

the Chief Minister stated that the newly launched 'Gaudham Yojana' aims to provide safe shelter to stray cattle, strengthen cattle conservation and contribute to rural economic growth.

He stated that Godhan has always been a key pillar of Chhattisgarh's rural culture, agricultural system, and village economy, and that the state government is therefore continuously working to protect it.

Sai emphasised that the state government is implementing the Gaudham Yojana in a phased manner across Chhattisgarh to ensure systematic care for stray cattle and to reinforce the tradition of Gau Seva.

MPOST

AHEAD OF 2027 POLLS

UP: Political parties invoke Kanshi Ram's legacy to woo Dalit voters

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: The birth anniversary of Kanshi Ram on March 15 is set to trigger intense political activity in Uttar Pradesh as major parties attempt to consolidate the Dalit vote ahead of the 2027 Assembly elections.

The Mayawati-led Bahujan Samaj Party has given a "Lucknow Chalao" call to party functionaries, aiming to stage a massive show of strength in the state capital and mobilise Dalit voters, who constitute nearly 21 percent of the electorate in the state.

Party sources said Mayawati is expected to outline the party's broader political strategy for the 2027 Assembly elections during the gathering. A similar programme is also proposed in Noida to extend the campaign's outreach.

Political observers say a large turnout at the event would signal that the BSP's organisational machinery, which has faced erosion in recent years, remains active. Party insiders said the initiative is also aimed at reminding Dalit voters that Kanshi Ram's political legacy belongs to the party he founded.

The ruling Bharatiya Janata

Party has also planned events across the state to mark the occasion. Party sources said the BJP's Scheduled Caste Morcha has been asked to collaborate with social organisations to highlight Kanshi Ram's legacy.

One of the key programmes is scheduled in Ghaziabad under the banner of a social organisation named after Ramabai Ambedkar, the wife of Dalit icon BR Ambedkar. The BJP has strategically chosen western Uttar Pradesh, a region with a significant population of Jatav voters who traditionally form the core support base of the BSP.

'AI cannot replace trained mind of lawyer, ethical responsibility of judge'

Justice Nath said false citations are not merely technical mistakes

OUR CORRESPONDENT

HYDERABAD: Used intelligently, AI may save time and make some aspects of legal work more manageable, but it cannot replace the trained mind of a lawyer, the ethical responsibility of an officer of the court or the disciplined judgment required of a judge, Supreme Court Judge, Justice Vikram Nath said on Saturday.

Addressing a conference here, Justice Nath further said technology may help draft a note, but it cannot be permitted to invent the law; at the same time, the misuse of AI cannot lead the judicial system to the opposite extreme of refusing to engage with it altogether.

Expressing concerns over the instances of AI-generated material having been used carelessly, even in the Supreme Court, including reference to citations and authorities that do not exist, Justice Nath said false citations are

Key Points

» Justice Nath further said that the technology may help draft a note, but it cannot be permitted to invent the law

» 'The advanced technologies and tools can assist legal work, but they can also create new forms of carelessness', said SC judge

not merely technical mistakes; they strike at the integrity of legal submissions and the credibility of the adjudicatory process itself.

"But a tool must remain a tool. It cannot replace the trained mind of a lawyer, the ethical responsibility of an officer of the court or the disciplined judgment required of a judge," Justice Nath said.

"Technology may help draft a note, but it cannot be permitted to invent the law. At the same time, the misuse of AI cannot lead us to the opposite extreme of refusing to engage with it altogether. The answer is informed use, ethical disci-

pline and professional standards. We must learn how to use these tools efficiently, carefully and with full awareness of their limitations," he said.

Therefore, the challenges are real as the technology can widen access, but it can also deepen exclusion. Though it can increase transparency, it can also encourage distortion, he said.

The advanced technologies and tools can assist legal work, but they can also create new forms of carelessness. It can help respond to crime and at the same time become the means through which new crimes are committed, the SC judge said.

Surrendered Maoist leader Devuji seeks lifting ban on CPI (Maoist)

HYDERABAD: CPI (Maoist) leader Thippiri Tirupati alias Devuji, who recently surrendered before Telangana Police, on Saturday demanded that the Centre lift the ban on the outfit and recognise it as a political party, though the organisation does not favour participating in electoral politics.

Speaking to news agency, he said his outfit is ready to lay down arms if it is recognised as a legal political party.

"We requested the Chief Minister (A Revanth Reddy, during a recent meeting) to bring the matter to the notice of the Centre (about lifting the ban). The CM responded positively and spoke to the Union Home Minister (Amit Shah). They say that only the government should have arms, and not others. We also say that we will handover arms if our party is recognised as a legal party," he said.

The CPI (Maoist) suffered losses as many Maoists were either arrested or died or surrendered after the Centre's anti-Maoist 'Operation Kagar' started, he said.

MPOST

Nation Briefs

ODISHA: THREE DIE IN ELEPHANT ATTACK IN KANDHAMAL

PHULBANI: Three persons were trampled to death by separate herds of elephants in the jungles of Kandhamal district, forest officials said Saturday. While two persons died at Damba forest in Petapanfa gram panchayat on Friday evening, another man met the same fate at Paburia forest on Saturday morning, they said. All three had gone to the forest to collect firewood, said Manikewari Patnaik, the forest range officer, G Udayagiri. The deceased persons were identified as Bama Pradhan (63), Kirtan Bugarty (65) and Duri Pradhan (32). The incidents sparked panic in the G Udayagiri area, where people prefer to remain indoors, fearing elephant attack. They alleged that the forest department did not alert the people regarding the movement of jumbo herds through their area.

LT GEN (RETD) SYED ATA HASNAIN SWORN IN AS BIHAR GOVERNOR

PATNA: Lt Gen (Retd) Syed Ata Hasnain took oath as the governor of Bihar on Saturday. Patna High Court Chief Justice Sangam Kumar Sahoo administered the oath of office and secrecy to Hasnain at a ceremony at the Lok Bhavan. Hasnain replaced Arif Mohammed Khan as the governor. The ceremony was attended by Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, his cabinet colleagues and senior officers, among others. Hasnain's last posting in uniform was as Military Secretary of the Indian Army, a key position responsible for senior-level personnel management. Prior to this, he commanded the Army's 15 Corps in J&K.

An English lesson for India

Fighting India lose 0-2 to England in qualifiers, but qualify for WC



England's players celebrate a goal

HOCKEY INDIA

HYDERABAD: The Indian women's hockey team lost 0-2 against the higher-ranked England to finish runners-up in the FIH Hockey World Cup Qualifiers but still managed to qualify for this year's mega-event, here on Saturday.

World No. 6 England scored through a penalty corner conversion by Grace Balsdon in the 13th minute before doubling their lead through a field strike from Elizabeth Neal in the 43rd minute.

The Indians, ranked ninth in the world, tried their heart and soul throughout the entire 60 minutes but failed to break the resolute English defence.

Besides champions England, runner-up India and Scotland, who defeated Italy 1-0, qualified from this event for the World Cup.

This edition of the World Cup will be jointly hosted by the Netherlands and Belgium

The Indians tried their heart and soul throughout the match but failed to break the resolute English defence

from August 14 to 30 along side the men's tournament.

India began the game on the front foot with Navneet Kaur helping her side earn a penalty corner within the opening two minutes.

However, her drag-flick from the resulting set piece was kept out by the England goalkeeper.

The hosts showed great discipline, maintaining a solid defensive shape while also making inroads on the end of the field. However, England grew into the game towards the

end of the first quarter, earning a penalty corner with two minutes to go.

Balsdon made the most of that opportunity, finding the back of the net with her drag-flick and scoring her fifth goal from a penalty corner in this tournament to give England the lead. The second quarter began in a similar manner, with both the teams not giving much away in this engaging contest.

With eight circle penetrations in the first half, India were asking questions to the England defence but didn't really test the rival goalkeeper, allowing the visitors to hold onto their one-goal advantage at half time.

With the lead, England controlled the tempo of the game by neatly working the ball and maintaining possession. India had a few opportunities to pile on the pressure, but the visitors stood firm at the back. AGENCIES

AHMEDABAD: Talented youngster Mayank Chakraborty crossed the final hurdle in his promising career by securing his third and final GM norm, becoming the 94th Grandmaster and the first from India's North-East region to achieve the coveted title.

Hailing from Guwahati in Assam, the 17-year-old Chakraborty -- who became an International Master in 2024 -- achieved the feat with a round to spare in the eighth round of the Hotel Stockholm North by First Hotels Chess Talents Tournament, defeating Swedish IM Philip Lindgren.

Chakraborty was at the top of his game in the victory over Lindgren, accumulating the required 6.5 points that were enough to secure his final Grandmaster norm. In the final round, he played out an exciting draw with English International Master Jonah B Willow

In Short

» He achieved the feat with a round to spare in the eighth round of the Hotel Stockholm North by First Hotels Chess Talents Tournament

» In 2024, Chakraborty had become an International Master and has been one of the top performers in his age group.

» Chakraborty also crossed the critical 2500 Elo rating mark in the



process, with his current rating standing a few points above the threshold

to seal what was his most memorable performance to date.

Chakraborty also crossed the critical 2500 Elo rating mark in the process, with his current rating standing a few points above the threshold,

thereby confirming the Grandmaster title as per the rules of the international chess federation, FIDE. Chakraborty lost one game, drew two and won the remaining six to finish with seven points out of nine. AGENCIES

Dhoni's last IPL? Irfan thinks so



As IPL nears, talks on MS Dhoni's future have already begun

FILE

NEW DELHI: Former India all-rounder Irfan Pathan believes the upcoming edition of the Indian Premier League could be the "last time" fans see MS Dhoni turning out for Chennai Super Kings.

As the 2026 IPL approaches, once again the talks surrounding Dhoni's retirement has again gathered pace.

The speculation intensified after CSK traded Sanju Samson from Rajasthan Royals, a move that many felt could allow the veteran to further minimise his on-field involvement this season while continuing to mentor the side. "CSK is incomplete without MS Dhoni. This season might be the last time we see him in the yellow jersey and it's tough to imagine CSK and the IPL without him," Irfan said.

"As soon as the IPL comes around, we start seeing Mahendra Singh Dhoni again, which means he is fully prepared for it, and he is looking very fit as well," he added.

The 44-year-old has already joined the CSK camp in Chennai earlier this month and has been training alongside the squad led by captain Ruturaj Gaikwad. Pathan said Dhoni's role could increasingly revolve around guiding the next generation of leaders develop within the side. AGENCIES

VALVERDE'S NIGHT IN THE SPOTLIGHT Real Madrid's 'V8' engine

DAMAN SINGH

NEW DELHI: With Jude Bellingham, Kylian Mbappé and Rodrygo missing from the line-up due to injuries, Manchester City arguably entered as favourites against Real Madrid in their Round-of-16 UEFA Champions League clash on Wednesday.

Pep Guardiola's side looked every bit the favourites — at least in the opening minutes.

Jérémy Doku burst into life almost immediately. The Belgian winger tore down the flank with a series of marauding runs, each sending a ripple of panic through Madrid's penalty area.

Defenders scrambled, the crowd gasped, and City sensed blood. Doku was just getting started, sizing up Trent Alexander-Arnold — and that certainly was bad news for the Englishman.

Then entered Federico Valverde.

The Uruguayan, who would steal the night with a hat-trick, snuffed out City's attempts to break through by consistently doubling up with his defensively frail teammate. He did so for most of the match.

A few minutes later, he delivered at the other end too. Collecting a glorious long ball from custodian Thibaut Courtois, he sped past marker Nico O'Reilly before rounding Gianluigi Donnarumma — sucker punch delivered.

That marked the beginning of a 22-minute hat-trick that had class written all over it.

Soon, the "little bird" — a nickname he earned for his lanky frame during his teenage years — spread his wings. He got his second in the 27th minute after latching onto a deflected pass from Vinicius Júnior, who had dribbled in from the left, finishing with a



Federico Valverde's historic treble vs Man City was one for the ages

AP

2

Valverde's hat-trick is the only second-ever by a Madrid midfielder in the European Cup/UCL era (after the 1960s)

def left-footed strike across Donnarumma.

His two quickfire goals were the fastest by a Real Madrid player in a Champions League knockout match at the Bernabéu since Cristiano Ronaldo's early double against Wolfsburg in April 2016. But nothing captured the night better than his third goal. A clever scoop from Brahim Diaz at the edge of the area saw Valverde take a Bergkamp-like first touch to flick the ball over Marc Guehi before volleying it in. And that was that. Valverde owned the night. The midfielder's hat-trick left the visitors feeling immured at the Santiago Bernabéu Stadium as the game wore on.

Omnipresent
From recoveries to tackles to goals, he seemed to be every-

where, hardly putting a foot wrong throughout the match.

The performance was so magnificent that L'Équipe, the renowned French newspaper, handed him a rare 10/10 rating. Praise has been pouring in ever since.

However, it wasn't always like this. The 27-year-old has been part of Madrid's first team for nearly a decade and has often gone under the radar for his services.

Playing in the shadows of illustrious predecessors like Luka Modrić, Toni Kroos and Casemiro didn't help either.

Under them, he developed a patina as a utility player. Now Madrid's captain, his versatility, knack for long-rangers and relentless running have become invaluable assets. He can slot in at left- or right-back, operate as a defensive midfielder or push forward in attack — wherever the team needs him.

This season too, he is the only outfield player to have logged the most minutes for Madrid. Now in his prime, it is fair to say Valverde has finally shed the "underrated" tag. Nights like these don't just underline his importance to Real Madrid — they confirm that he has grown from a dependable workhorse into one of the defining midfielders of his generation.

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
E-Tendering Tender Notice

Divisional Railway Manager (Works) N.C. Railway, Jhansi for and behalf of President of India invites sealed "Open Tender" through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following work.

E-Tender No. : JHS-ENGG-C-2026-30

Approx Cost : 81879000.00

Description of work : Supply, stacking and mechanized loading of 150000 m³ machine crushed track ballast as per Railway specification IRS-GE-I-June 2016 or latest at Khajraha depot under ADEN/Lalitpur sub division.

Earnest Money : 559400.00

Date of closing Tender : 06.04.2026 at 15:00 hrs.

Date of completion/period from issue acceptance letter : 15 Months.

* Tender online can be submitted upto to 15:00 hrs on 06.04.2026 * For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in

572/26 (AS)

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www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
"PUBLIC NOTIFICATION"

Notice is given to all user of Railway line and premises situated on the completed section of Dadri Station of North Central Railway, 2x25 kV DER/SSP will be energized on or after 20/03/2026 in the following section around the railway line. On or from this date the overhead line will at all times be treated as a live line and no unauthorized person shall approach or work in the proximity of the said overhead line.

Section: Enerzisation of New Dadri SSP in connection with raising of speed to 160 Kmph/200 Kmph. Design, Supply, Erection, Testing and Commissioning of 132kV/2x25 kV Traction Sub-station along with SP/SSPs between Ghaziabad-Pt. Deen Dayal Upadhyay on existing New Delhi-Howrah Route of North Central Railway

KM / Location / Chainage From-To

Dadri SSP Km. 1417/14 (CH 1417/416.30) from Dadri SSP Km. 1417/18 (CH 1417/542.30) to

Date of Energization:- 20.03.2026

(Chander Pal)

Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer/Project

North Central Railway, Kanpur

585/26(D)

North central railways

www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

@ CPONCR

DELHI TRANSCO LIMITED

NOTICE INVITING e-TENDERS

Delhi Transco Ltd, (A Government of NCT of Delhi Undertaking), invites online tenders for the following works :

Tender No.T25P131615: Construction and Modification of 315 MVA transformer miscellaneous works at 400 KV Bannauli Substation

For complete details of the tender please visit following websites:-
https://govtprocurement.delhi.gov.in (Tender ID No. 2026_DTL_288496_1) and www.dtl.gov.in with Unique No. DTL-9929-120326.

Last date for bid submission: 30.03.2026 at 13.00 Hrs.

*All corrigendum/ Addendum/ Amendments/ Date of Extensions/ Clarifications etc. to this e-tender will be hosted on the above website only. Bidders should regularly visit website to keep themselves updated.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(SEE SECTION 82 (2) (ii) Cr.P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Loveneet Yadav S/o Ram Sewak Yadav R/o H. No. B-458, Street No. 6, Prem Vihar, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in Case **FIR No. 392/2025, U/s 109(1)/3(5) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita & 25A Act, PS Karawal Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Loveneet Yadav** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Loveneet Yadav** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant), Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Loveneet Yadav** of Case **FIR No. 392/2025, U/s 109(1)/3(5) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita & 25A Act, PS Karawal Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **20.04.2026**

By Order

Isra Jaidi

Judicial Magistrate First Class-04

Room No. 64, 4th Floor, North-East Dist.

Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/3148/NE/2026

(Court Matter)

वरिय पुलिस अधीक्षक का कार्यालय, राँची ।
सर्वसाधारण के लिए सूचना ।

नाम-रिया सिंह, उम्र-19 वर्ष, उँचाई-5 फीट 5 ईंच, रंग-साँवला, पहनावा-किम रंग का फ्रिटेड सलवार सूट पहनी हुई है ।
उपरोक्त लापता महिला रिया सिंह, उम्र-19 वर्ष, पिता-बजरंग सिंह, साठ-बढ़ैया, थाना-चाहो, जिला-राँची, जो दिनांक-08.03.2026 को घर से बगैर बताए कहीं चली जो आजतक अपने घर वापस नहीं आई है । जिसके संबंध में चाहो थाना सनहा संख्या-13 / 2026, दिनांक-11.03.2026 दर्ज कर इनकी खोजबीन की जा रही है । उपरोक्त सूचना को सार्वजनिक किया जाना आवश्यक है ।

अतः सभी जनसाधारण से अनुरोध है कि यदि उपरोक्त लापता महिला कहीं मिली/दिखती है तो इसके संबंध में वरिय पुलिस अधीक्षक के कार्यालय में या निम्नांकित फोन नम्बर पर संपर्क कर इसकी सूचना दें ।
Email ID(mc-dcb@jhpoliche.gov.in)

पुलिस उपाधीक्षक, खलारी, राँची ।

—943170619

थाना प्रभारी, चाहो, राँची ।

—9431706187

वरिय पुलिस अधीक्षक, राँची ।

PR 375094 Police(25-26)JD

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

No. : Dy.CEE/PU/CNB/25-26

Dated : 13.03.2026

PUBLIC NOTIFICATION

Notice is given to all user of Railway line and premises situated on the completed section of Aligarh Station of North Central Railway, 2x25 kV ALJN/SSP will be energized on or after 20.04.2026 in the following section around the railway line. On or from this date the overhead line will at all times be treated as a live line and no unauthorized person shall approach or work in the proximity of the said overhead line.

Date of Energization : 20.04.2026

Section	KM/Location/Chainage	
	From	To
Enerzisation of New Aligarh SSP in connection with raising of speed to 160 Kmph/200 Kmph. Design, Supply, Erection, Testing and Commissioning of 132kV/2x25 kV Traction Sub-station along with SP/SSPs between Ghaziabad-Pt. Deen Dayal Upadhyay on existing New Delhi-Howrah Route of North Central Railway.	Aligarh/SSP Km. 1328/10 (CH 1328/251.0)	Aligarh/SSP Km. 1328/12 (CH 1328/301)

Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer/Project

North Central Railway, Kanpur

584/26 (C)

North central railways

www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

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Saina urges BWF to keep 15-point system

NEW DELHI: Olympics medallist Saina Nehwal has urged the Badminton World Federation (BWF) to exercise caution regarding proposed scoring changes, maintaining that the current 21-point system preserves the sport's essential intensity and endurance.

The game's governing body (BWF) has proposed switching to a 3x15 scoring format from the current 3x21 system, with a membership vote on the change scheduled at the BWF Annual General Meeting in Horsens, Denmark on April 25.

"Badminton has a rich tradition, and tournaments like the All England Open Badminton Championships and the BWF World Championships have always been special because of their intensity and endurance factor," Saina, who joined the advisory board of India's International Movement to Unite Nations (I.I.M.U.N.), said in an interview. "Any change in scoring or format should be carefully considered. The current 21-point system has



worked well and players have adapted to it over many years. If changes are introduced, they should ensure that the quality of rallies and the competitive balance of the sport are not affected. At the end of the day, the focus should remain on fair competition and the spirit of the game."

According to the revamped BWF World Tour, the five Super 1000 tournaments, to be staged across Asia and Europe, will introduce a new format in singles, with 48 players competing in a group stage followed by knockouts. Doubles events will feature 32-pair knockout draws, and each Super 1000 tournament will run for 11 days across two weekends. AGENCIES

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPc/84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused 1. **Habibul, S/o: Sheikh Rahibulla, R/o: Jhuggi No. H-4/N-30, Jahangirpuri, Delhi, 2. Samidul, S/o: Sanwar, R/o: G-Block, Jahangirpuri, Delhi** have committed (or are suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 000433/2023 U/s 380/454/411/34 IPC, P.S.: Keshav Puram, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused 1. **Habibul & 2. Samidul** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused 1. **Habibul & 2. Samidul** have absconded (or are concealing themselves to avoid the service of the said warrant), Proclamation is hereby made that the said 1. **Habibul & 2. Samidul** accused of offence in case **FIR No. 000433/2023 U/s 380/454/411/34 IPC, P.S.: Keshav Puram, Delhi** and are required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **22.05.2026**

By Order

Sh. Sanyam Jain

Judicial Magistrate First Class-04 (North West)

Room No. 112,

Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/3205/NW/2026

(Court Matter)

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

No. : PU-CNB-W-02-2026

Dated : 11.03.2026

E-Tender Notice

Dy. Chief Signal & Telecom Engineer/Project, North Central Railway Project Unit, Kanpur for and on behalf of the President of India invites open e-Tender from reputed contractors/JV firms with adequate experience and financial capability, for the following work on Signal Packet System up to 13:00 hrs. on the opening date of E-tender mentioned therein. If date of opening is declared a holiday or offer could not be opened due to Technical issue, the offers shall be opened on the next working day.

The details of the Tender are as under:

E-Tender No. : PU-CNB-W-02-2026

Name of work : "Construction of Station Service Building along with associated miscellaneous works at NYN station and Construction of S&T Service Buildings in section & other miscellaneous civil works in the jurisdiction of Dy. CSTE/PU/CNB in Prayagraj Division of North Central Railway"

Estimated cost of work : Approx. Cost Rs. 44011752.65 only (Four Crore Forty Lakh Eleven thousand Seven Hundred Fifty Two and Paise Sixty Five only)

Earnest Money : Rs. 370100.00 (Three Lakh Seventy thousand & One hundred only.)

Tender form cost : NIL.

Completion Period : 12 Months.

Availability of tender form : Tender forms shall be available on web site, www.ireps.gov.in. 21 days prior to date of opening of the tender.

Closing Date/Time of Tender : 02.04.2026 before 13:00 Hrs.

Tender Opening Date/Time : 02.04.2026 at 13:00 Hrs.

Place of Opening : Through Online E-Portal www.ireps.gov.in in the office of CSTE/P-II/NCRPU, HQ Office, Subedarganj, Prayagraj (UP)

Validity of Offer : 45 days from date of opening.

Right of Railway to deal with tender : Railway administration reserves the rights to postpone/modify or to cancel the tender without assigning any reasons.

Tenders who wish to participate in tenders invited on www.ireps.gov.in have to register on the website mandatorily. Please refer to website for more details. Tenderers can submit EMD only through online mode. Online payment of earnest money can be made through net banking, debit/credit card etc. Further particulars can be obtained from Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in. 568/26 (C)

North central railways

www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

@ CPONCR

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Rakesh Kumar, S/o Preem Singh R/o E-2/374, Sultanpuri, Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case, **FIR No. 486/2016, U/s 420/467/468/471/506 PS: North Rohini Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Rakesh Kumar** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Rakesh Kumar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant), Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Rakesh Kumar** accused of **FIR No. 486/2016, U/s 420/467/468/471/506 PS: North Rohini Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **14.05.2026**

By Order

Ms. Ebbani Aggarwal

JMFC-03 Room No.107

Rohini Court Delhi

DP/3251/RD/2026

(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Chandrika Prasad, S/o: Binda Prasad, R/o: A-24/11, Dass Garden, Baprola, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 638/22 U/s 420/406/34 IPC, P.S.: Ranhola, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Chandrika Prasad** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Chandrika Prasad** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant), Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Chandrika Prasad** accused of offence in case **FIR No. 638/22 U/s 420/406/34 IPC, P.S.: Ranhola, Delhi** and is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **21.05.2026**

By Order

Sh. Ankit Karan Singh

Judicial Magistrate First Class-08 (West)

Room No. 30, Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/3061/OD/2026

(Court Matter)



As artificial intelligence becomes central to military planning and targeting, the infrastructure that powers the digital economy — data centres, cloud systems and AI platforms — is increasingly emerging as a strategic battlefield

AUTHOR



DIPANKAR DEY

Data centres — the physical buildings that house all the infrastructure required to power banking apps, cloud services, and artificial intelligence platforms — are the new targets during the ongoing war involving Israel, the USA, and the Islamic Republic of Iran. Amazon said two of its data centres in the United Arab Emirates (UAE) were hit by drone strikes on March 1, and a third centre in Bahrain was damaged by debris from a nearby strike. Iran’s Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) claimed responsibility for the attacks, telling their state media that the attacks were ‘aimed to identify the role of these centres in supporting the enemy’s military and intelligence activities’. The strikes swiftly brought the war directly into the lives of 11 million people in the UAE, nine out of 10 of whom are foreign nationals. Millions of people in Dubai and Abu Dhabi woke up the next morning unable to pay for a taxi, order food delivery, or check their bank balance on their mobile apps. Iran warned that US tech firms, including Google, Microsoft, and Palantir, could become targets as the war expands.

RISE IN USE OF AI IN WAR — A CONTENTIOUS TREND

AI’s unprecedented use in the Iran crisis signals profound changes in the way the world wages war. The U.S. military was able to strike a blistering 1,000 targets in the first 24 hours of its attack on Iran, thanks in part to its use of artificial intelligence. The military has used Claude, the AI tool from Anthropic, combined with Palantir’s Maven system, for real-time targeting and target prioritisation in support of combat operations in Iran and Venezuela.

According to experts, military AI refers to a huge collection of different systems and tasks. The two main categories of military AI are: automated weapons and decision support systems. Automated weapon systems have some ability to select or engage targets by themselves. Decision support systems, in contrast, are now at the heart of most modern militaries. These

are software applications that provide intelligence and planning information to human personnel. Many military applications of AI, including in current and recent wars in the Middle East, are for decision support systems rather than weapons. Claude is embedded in the Maven Smart System, used widely by military, intelligence, and law enforcement organisations. The Israeli Lavender and Gospel systems used in the Gaza war and elsewhere are also decision support systems.

Anthropic’s AI tool Claude is playing a key role in the U.S. military’s campaign in Iran, observes the Washington Post.

Anthropic’s Claude has reportedly been vital to the massive and intensifying offensive, which has already killed an estimated thousand-plus civilians in Iran. This is an era of bombing “quicker than the speed of thought”, with AI identifying and prioritising targets, recommending weaponry, and evaluating legal grounds for a strike, experts told The Guardian.

Anthropic PBC — founded in 2021 by seven former employees of OpenAI — is an American artificial intelligence (AI) company headquartered in San Francisco. As of February 2026, Anthropic has an estimated value of USD 380 billion. It operates as a public benefit corporation

that researches and develops AI. In September 2023, Amazon announced a partnership with Anthropic. As part of the deal, Anthropic uses Amazon Web Services (AWS) as its primary cloud provider and makes its AI models available to Amazon Web Services customers.

In September 2025, Anthropic announced that it would stop selling its products to groups with majority shares owned by Chinese, Russian, Iranian, or North Korean entities due to national security concerns. In October 2025, Anthropic announced a cloud partnership with Google, and in November 2025, NVIDIA, Microsoft, and Anthropic

proclaimed a partnership deal. NVIDIA and Microsoft were expected to invest up to USD 15 billion in Anthropic.

Recently, Anthropic has become the central actor in a high-profile fight with the US Department of Defence (DoD) over the company’s refusal to allow Claude to be used for domestic mass surveillance and autonomous weapons systems that can kill people without human input. Amid tense negotiations, the AI firm rejected a Pentagon deadline for a deal last week, in a move that led Pete Hegseth, the defence secretary, to accuse Anthropic of “arrogance and betrayal” of its home country. Meanwhile, Trump denounced Anthropic in an interview, saying he “fired them like dogs”. On Thursday, the DoD formally declared Anthropic a supply-chain risk and demanded that other businesses cut ties — the first time an American company has ever been targeted, which poses grave financial consequences for the company if fully enacted.

Significantly, Anthropic’s integration into the military began with a 2024 deal with Palantir to allow Claude to be used within its systems, which already operated in classified environments. The two companies touted the agreement as a way to drastically reduce the resources and time needed for military operations and intelligence gathering. The following year, Anthropic, along with several other major AI companies, struck a USD 200m deal with the DoD to use their AI tools for military operations.

Anthropic’s recent standoff with the DoD is seen by tech analysts as reflecting the AI firm’s inherent contradictions. It is a company founded on the premise of ‘creating a safe future for AI’, which has nevertheless struck major partnerships for classified work with the Pentagon and surveillance tech giant Palantir. Its leadership now says it is deeply worried about the existential risks of AI, though they recently dropped a founding safety pledge, citing the speed of industry competition, observes The Guardian.

A group of experts argues that increasing military use of AI is essentially making humans more important in war, not less. People have preferences, values, and commitments regarding real-world outcomes, but AI systems intrinsically do not. The incident of the Tomahawk cruise missile that struck a girls’ school adjacent to an Iranian naval base, killing about 175 students, is a case in point.

pose a serious environmental threat to the locations where they are placed.

As the use of AI proliferates, environmental policy analysts, academic researchers, and others are raising concerns about the impacts the data centers powering the technology are having on communities, ecosystems, and the climate. Among those concerns are the immense energy and water resources the centers require and the air, light, noise, and other pollution they generate. By 2030, data centers’ global electricity use is estimated to more than double to 945 terawatt-hours, a little more than Japan’s total electricity consumption in 2024, according to a report published in April 2025 by the International Energy Agency.

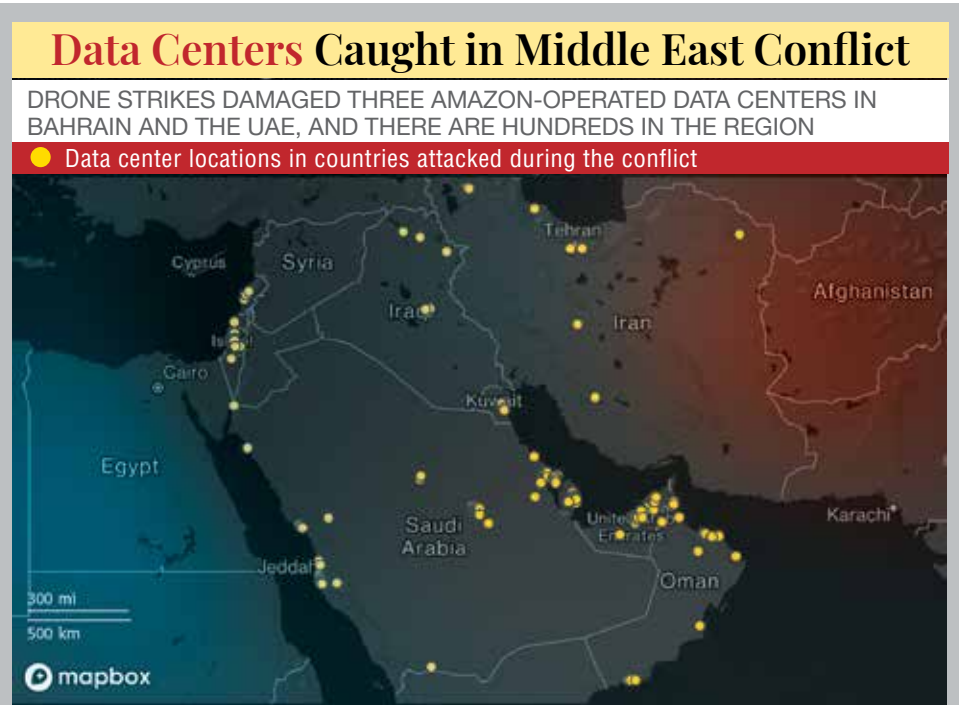
The environmental footprint of AI data centers is well documented. It is observed that as energy demand increases, the companies behind AI lean on dirty sources such as gas and coal to keep things running. One proposed data center facility in New Mexico is called Project Jupiter. Developers intend to generate 2,880 megawatts at the facility using “simple-cycle gas turbines” to power two “microgrids” at the projected USD 165 billion campus. Local advocates are opposing the construction on environmental grounds. Tech giants such as Meta, Microsoft, and Google have turned to nuclear power for a steady supply. The low cost of solar and wind power remains highly competitive, but their share of the power supply for data centers remains relatively low compared with natural gas.

Powerful computers that run A.I. also get extremely hot. So, to keep them from overheating, data centers cool them with powerful air-conditioning systems that are run by water. In March 2024, Forbes reported that the water consumption associated with a single conversation with ChatGPT was comparable to that of a standard plastic water bottle. Even a mid-sized data center consumes as much water as a small town, while larger ones require up to 5 million gallons of water every day — as much as a city of 50,000 people.

GROWING PROTEST AGAINST DATA CENTERS

As tech companies build data centers worldwide to advance artificial intelligence, vulnerable communities have been hit by blackouts and water shortages. A report by the Data Center Watch reveals that between May 2024 and March 2025, USD 18 billion worth of data center projects were blocked, and another USD 46 billion of projects were delayed over the last two years in the face of opposition from residents and activist groups. There are at least 142 activist groups across 24 states in the USA organising to block data center construction and expansion.

Nearly 60 per cent of the 1,244 largest data centers in the world were outside the United States as of the end of June 2025, according to an analysis by Synergy Research Group, which studies the industry. More are coming, with at least 575 data center projects in development globally from companies including Tencent, Meta, and Alibaba. From Mexico to Ireland, fury mounts over a global AI frenzy. In Ireland, data centers consume more than 20 per cent of the country’s electricity. In Chile, precious aquifers are in danger of depletion. In South Africa, where blackouts have long been routine, data centers are further taxing the national grid. Similar concerns have surfaced in Brazil, Britain, India, Malaysia, the Netherlands, Singapore, and Spain. The missile attack on the Amazon data centers in the UAE adds a new challenge to the AI industry.



BATTLEFIELDS OF THE ALGORITHM AGE

AI-ASSISTED MILITARY STRIKES
Artificial intelligence helped the U.S. military reportedly strike around 1,000 targets within the first 24 hours of attacks on Iran, using systems that analyse surveillance data and prioritise targets in real time.

DATA CENTRES BECOME STRATEGIC TARGETS
Drone strikes hit two Amazon data centres in the UAE, while another facility in Bahrain was damaged by debris. The incident disrupted banking, transport and food-delivery apps for millions of users.

AI PLATFORMS IN COMBAT PLANNING
AI models such as Anthropic’s Claude, integrated with Palantir’s Maven system, analyse satellite imagery, drone feeds and intelligence data to assist commanders in identifying and prioritising targets.

TECH GIANTS AND DEFENCE PARTNERSHIPS
Companies including Amazon, Microsoft, Google and NVIDIA now provide cloud infrastructure, AI models and computing power that support intelligence analysis and military operations.

DATA CENTRES AS STRATEGIC INFRASTRUCTURE
More than 1,200 large data centres operate worldwide, with over 575 additional projects under development, making them critical infrastructure — and potential targets — in modern conflicts.



EXPERTS WARN
AI CANNOT REPLACE
HUMAN JUDGEMENT IN WAR
BECAUSE
machines lack
VALUES, EMPATHY AND
UNDERSTANDING OF
CONSEQUENCES

DATA CENTERS — A NEW HAZARD

Data centers are the critical physical infrastructure powering



59 LAKH

ESTIMATED USED
CARS SOLD IN INDIA
IN FY 2024-25



62% HOUSEHOLDS

FIRST-TIME CAR BUYERS
INCREASINGLY ENTER THE MARKET
THROUGH USED VEHICLES



2:1 RATIO

IN SEVERAL CITIES, USED
CAR SALES ALREADY EXCEED
NEW CAR SALES



Dashing Cheetah? OR Lame Horse?

AUTHOR



RAJEEV NARAYAN

*India's booming used-car bazaar promises dream wheels
at irresistible prices – but behind the purr and polish
may lurk breakdowns and very costly surprises*

It is India's Greatest Bazaar, the used-car market that resembles a Sunday flea market. Only, the toys are heavier, shinier and capable of either making your dream come true or bankrupting you if you choose unwisely. In this market, there is temptation everywhere. A near-new sedan that costs half its original price. A once-luxury SUV whose seat-leather still smells faintly of prosperity. A hatchback that promises urban freedom at the price of a smartphone upgrade. Alongside you, the buyers line up.

Such is India's pre-owned car market, the fastest-growing segment of the auto economy. Around 59 lakh used cars were sold in FY 2024-25, and the number is projected to grow sharply to 95 lakh to 1 crore units annually by 2030. The second-hand market has already overtaken new car sales in volume, driven by rising vehicle prices, tighter budgets and the lure of better features at lower cost.

For many Indians, the logic is irresistible. Why buy a bare-bones

new hatchback when the same money fetches a three-year-old sedan with airbags, diamond-cut alloy wheels and an infotainment screen that looks like it belongs to Captain James T. Kirk and his starship USS Enterprise? The universe treasure hunt for four gleaming wheels begins.

COULD BE HIDDEN GEMS

Truth be told, the used-car bazaar is not all about mechanical mischief, and some offerings do make for fantastic bargains. Consider the cars that never quite found buyers when new. Dealers occasionally offload slow-moving inventory into the used-car pipeline with heavy discounts. The result is a virtually new vehicle with negligible mileage, available at a price that makes accountants weep with joy.

Then there are some cherished machines; the cars owned by enthusiasts. These are rare breeds whose engines have been warmed up gently, whose service schedules are followed with religious devotion, and whose interiors are cleaned with more care than the owner's living

room. Even if such cars have clocked serious kilometres, they remain mechanically sound and visibly rapturous. Their mileage is but a number; their maintenance is the true biography.

In our growing organised pre-owned ecosystem of dealer networks, certified platforms and inspection systems, such gems are becoming visible. Reports suggest that 70 per cent of buyers prefer organised sellers because of perceived transparency and certification. The platforms promise inspection reports, warranties and buy-back guarantees. For cautious buyers, they are a welcome layer of protection in what used to be a purely trust-based marketplace. But even polished bazaars have dark corners.

THEM DARKER CORNERS

For every pampered car, there exist a 100 that have lived rather more colourful lives. And the used-car ecosystem includes a thriving underground world of improvisation and ingenuity – desi jugaad. Some vehicles that appear immaculate on the outside are, when internally dissected, mechanical jigsaw puzzles. Engines or parts are replaced with questionable substitutes. Gearboxes are assembled from parts sourced like spare screws at a hardware store. Accident-damaged cars are straightened, repainted and presented as pristine specimens of the auto world.

There are dealers who treat cars less like machines and more like gold mines. A functioning component removed here, another swapped there; each part sold separately before the skeletal remains are pimped up for sale. The unsuspecting buyer discovers the truth only after the honeymoon ends. And his romp

on the road is short-lived. The car that gleamed seductively under the lights begins to cough and sputter. The suspension groans like an ageing actor. The electrical system develops moods that would embarrass a once-hot diva. This is that dreadful moment when bargain makes way for liability.

BUYERS BETTER BEWARE

Triple B. This is why buying a used car demands more than enthusiasm. It requires suspicion, patience and a good mechanic.

A proper inspection is essential, preferably by someone who knows that an engine bay can reveal secrets in seconds. A test drive is not a luxury; it is a diagnosis. To listen to the engine. Feel the steering. Watch the exhaust. Study the service history like a stubborn cop would alibis.

Even documentation deserves scrutiny. Ownership records, insurance claims and accident histories can reveal stories that glossy paint jobs will never fess up to. The reason may be duplicitous, but it is simple: the used-car market is expanding faster than regulation and transparency.

Crisil estimates the sector will grow 8-10 per cent annually, faster than new car sales volumes,

even as its value approaches Rs 4 lakh crore. Sardonicly, that is just about the size of the new-car market too. When an industry grows this quickly, quality has no option but to become suspect.

THE ROAD AHEAD

Let's face facts. The boom in the used-car market is not merely a commercial phenomenon; it is also a social quagmire. For lakhs of middle-class households, a used car is the first step into private four-wheeled mobility. It is the family's first highway trip, the first school drop-off sans a crowded bus, the first taste of automotive independence. Viewed through this aspirational lens, the second-hand car is not a mere machine. It is an economic ladder.

Given the sheer desire and lust for wheels in India, the next phase of the used-car market will perforce depend on trust. Organised players, certified inspection systems, digital marketplaces and transparent pricing mechanisms must somehow replace the opaque bargaining culture that still dominates many corners of the trade.

Technology can help. Vehicle-history databases, AI-driven inspection tools and digital documentation are already beginning to reduce uncertainty in transactions. And, ahem, regulators can help too. By tightening standards around accident disclosures, odometer tampering and dealer accountability. If tech and watchdogs help, the used-car ecosystem could become one of the most dynamic mobility markets in the world. An efficient circular economy where vehicles live multiple productive lives.

Until then, though, every buyer entering the used car bazaar faces an eternal question – is the machine standing before him or her a dashing buck, ready to gallop without complaint? Or is it merely a lame horse, waiting patiently for its next unsuspecting rider, who will soon discover its hobble?



BUYER
BEWARE



CHECKS
BEFORE
BUYING A
USED CAR

INSPECT THE ENGINE CAREFULLY

Open the bonnet and check for oil leaks, unusual noises or freshly cleaned engine parts that may hide problems.

STUDY THE SERVICE HISTORY

A properly maintained car should have regular service records from authorised workshops or trusted mechanics.

CHECK ACCIDENT AND INSURANCE RECORDS

Past insurance claims often reveal whether the vehicle has been involved in major accidents.

TEST DRIVE THOROUGHLY

Drive on different road conditions to observe engine response, braking, steering alignment and suspension behaviour.

VERIFY OWNERSHIP DOCUMENTS

Confirm registration papers, RC transfer history, loan clearance and ensure the chassis and engine numbers match records.

Part I

EVOLUTION OF CLIMATE MODELS



Climate models combine physics, mathematics and computing to simulate the Earth's atmosphere, oceans and land systems and forecast future climate trends

AUTHOR



KRISHNA GUPTA

In this series on Climate Change, we briefly discussed climate models such as General Climate Models (GCMs) and Earth System Models (ESMs) in earlier articles. There is, in fact, a hierarchy of such models depending on their complexity and their coverage. In this two-part article, we will look at a variety of climate models. In Part 1, we will examine the evolution of climate models and introduce basic climate models.

CLIMATE MODELS: AN INTRODUCTION

There are various climate models that range from simple Energy Balance Models to complex Earth System Models. While simple models take a slice of the whole picture and describe a part of the climate system, complex models such as Earth System Models take the entire climate system into account, including the oceans, atmosphere, land, ice sheets and the carbon cycle.

More generally, a climate model is a representation of the climate system, which consists of the atmosphere, oceans, land (forests and vegetation) and ice sheets. These are expressed in mathematical equations based on the laws of physics, such as the conservation of energy, momentum and mass, the laws of thermodynamics, and Newton's second law of motion. These climate models, consisting of simultaneous equations, are run as iterative computer programs and help us make climate projections.

Most climate models divide the Earth's surface into grids or boxes of about 100 km by 100 km. Energy, mass and momentum flow across these boxes, as do water and air. Variables such as temperature, humidity and wind velocity (both horizontal and vertical) are calculated for each box for one "time step" or time period, which typically ranges from a few seconds to 30 minutes. The equations are solved one time step at a time, and the results are then used for the next time step. This produces a series of values for variables such as temperature, humidity and wind.

The earliest modern climate model was proposed by Norman Phillips in 1956, when he undertook a simulation of the general atmosphere. Around the same time, John von Neumann initiated a conference in 1955 to discuss General Circulation Models (GCMs), which led to important institutional developments in climate modelling. The Geophysical Fluid Dynamics Laboratory (GFDL) was set up in 1955 by Smagorinsky and Manabe. The UCLA Meteorology Laboratory

was established in the late 1950s by Yale Mintz and Akio Arakawa, and the National Center for Atmospheric Research (NCAR) was established in Boulder, Colorado, in the early 1960s.

In addition, the UK Meteorological Office proposed the Numerical Weather Prediction model in 1965 and a General Climate Model in 1973. The first ocean GCMs were developed at GFDL by Bryan and Cox in the 1960s, and these were later coupled with atmospheric models by Manabe and Bryan in the 1970s. Syukuro Manabe of GFDL was awarded the Nobel Prize in Physics in 2021 for his work on modelling the effects of carbon dioxide on global warming.

The earliest GCMs were produced at GFDL in the 1960s by Bryan and Cox.

HIERARCHY OF CLIMATE MODELS

The various climate models range from the simplest Energy Balance Models to the more complex General Circulation Models (GCMs) and Earth System Models (ESMs). Let us discuss these briefly.

The simplest models are the Energy Balance Models (EBMs) with zero dimensions. These treat the Earth as a single unit and examine the incoming and outgoing radiation of the Earth without taking into account variations across latitudes and longitudes. The global mean temperature is determined by the net balance between incoming and outgoing radiation.

CLIMATE MODELS are among the most powerful tools scientists use to understand the Earth's changing climate

If latitudes are introduced into the basic zero-dimension EBM, we obtain a one-dimensional EBM, and the energy budget equation is solved separately for each latitude, with the atmosphere and oceans being treated as a single box. If vertical energy transfer is included in one-dimensional EBMs, they are referred to as radiative-convective models.

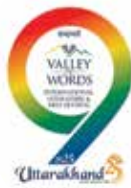
If energy and moisture exchange across zones is included, we arrive at models of intermediate complexity. These range from two-dimensional EBMs with energy and moisture transport to one-dimensional EBMs coupled with either ocean or atmospheric models.

General Circulation Models (GCMs) are at the top of the hierarchy of climate models, along with Earth System Models (ESMs). GCMs take into account all the physical processes that occur in the oceans and atmosphere and model them based on the laws of physics.

We will continue this discussion and provide more details on GCMs, ESMs and other developments in climate modelling in the next part.

Caste, Merit and a Chat

In *Removed From The WhatsApp*, Pankaj Rangari turns a school WhatsApp fallout into a sharp reflection on caste, reservation and the idea of fraternity



AUTHOR



SANJEEV CHOPRA

In the Great Trigonometrical Survey of India conducted in 1907, the Zero Milestone (ZM), used to measure distances across the country, was established at Nagpur. Featuring four horses and a pillar made of yellow sandstone, the ZM is located at the intersection of lines connecting major metro cities—Mumbai, Chennai, Kolkata, and New Delhi—making it the heart of the Indian subcontinent. Geography aside, it is also the headquarters of the RSS, the ideological fountainhead of Hindutva thought, on the one hand, and is also the site of the sacred monument Deekshabhumi, a major pilgrimage centre of Navayana Buddhism, where Dr B.R. Ambedkar converted to Buddhism on October 14, 1956. To him can be traced the incorporation of provisions relating to reservations for SCs and STs, which were later extended to the non-creamy OBCs in 1990 and to EWS in 2019.

TWO NAGPUR-BASED BOOKS

The opening paragraph is important, for this is also the city of Sushila Takbaure, whose Hindi book *Shikanje Ka Dard* was recently translated into English as *A Shackled Life* and reviewed in this column a few weeks ago. This week's book is also a Nagpur-based entry in the genre of non-fiction: *Removed from the WhatsApp: A Bitter Tale of Caste and Reservation ~ Two Perspectives ~ One Nation*, written by engineer and proud Ambedkarite Pankaj Rangari. As the name suggests, this is based on a real-life exclusion from a school WA group of middle-aged professionals. Spread across cities and continents, the digital reunion after twenty-four years (since 1997) was 'like opening a time capsule'. Old friends swapped photos, stories of teenage infatuation, receding hairlines, and the struggles of ballooning midlines. All this was fine—but then, one fine morning, after a group member forwarded posts and messages ridiculing caste-based reservations in education and employment, all hell broke loose. Before sunset that evening, fault



lines had become more than visible in questioning the very element of 'fraternity', which, along with liberty and equality, is embedded as a founding principle in the Preamble to our Constitution.

Let's take a look at this group of eight active members (and others who come in with their occasional insights). This includes our protagonist NM and his mentor KK, an Ambedkar acolyte who supports reservation and is willing to engage on this subject with conceptual clarity, empirical data, and the arguments brought up while signing the Poona Pact. Then we have a well-educated Brahmin boy (KJ) who professes a liberal outlook but supports the caste system as divinely ordained. The third is a Brahmin girl (DN) from a family of priests, who opposes reservation, albeit less vehemently, since she sometimes takes a neutral stand. The next member of the group (PB) is an ancestral landowner from the Kshatriya caste who rejects caste and opposes reservation. An OBC girl, KB, from a traditional

background with no clear views on the reservation debate, is the fifth member of the group. The sixth, an OBC male, SD, is aware of the evils of the caste system and takes advantage of the reservation while arguing against it. Then there is the ST (ML) male who has leveraged the reservation to his benefit but prefers to remain silent on the reservation debate. The eighth (SG) is an SC girl from a well-educated Ambedkarite family who vocally supports reservation.

As many of us are aware, administrators of WhatsApp groups often stipulate that controversial topics like religion, reservation, and politics should be avoided. However, whether we like it or not, the subject does come up—sometimes deliberately, but often inadvertently in the guise of a debate on 'merit'. During T20 and other cricket matches, the debate becomes more toxic when comments like extending the quota to sport are made rather loosely. Then there are the odd comments which we are all familiar with about the lackadaisical quality of engineers and medicos from the 'special stream'.

Our protagonist helps us steer this conversation by talking of five big ideas. The first of these is the Constitutional Promise, for the right to vote is not synonymous with social equality. Then there is the Historical Wound—the brutal realities of caste which refuse to die down in our social discourse and interaction. The third is the Merit Myth, which insulates talent from context, especially when those who sit in judgment are blissfully

unaware of their own implicit bias(es). The Time Frame required to correct these anomalies is the fourth point, but this depends more on the on-ground situation rather than propositions on paper. Last but not least is the strongest—that of Human Connection, which offers a possibility to bridge deep ideological fissures.

KK helps NM understand the finer nuances of the debate by listing the thirteen historical milestones in the reservation discourse: starting with the Hunter Commission of 1882, which in turn was based on the memorandum of Jyotiba Phule. This was followed by the Morley-Minto reforms of 1909, which expanded the Legislative Councils but introduced separate electorates for Muslims. The 1919 Southborough Committee, before which Ambedkar now proposed a separate electorate for the Depressed Classes, came next. In 1920, under the auspices of Manegam Parishad, a pact was signed between Ambedkar and the Kolhapur ruler Sahu Maharaj. Four years later, the Bahishkrit Hitkarini Sabha adopted the mantra of 'Educate, Agitate, Organise'. This was followed by the Mahad Satyagraha in 1927 on the right to access drinking water from the Chavdar tank. The seventh milestone was Dr Ambedkar's representation to the Simon Commission. This was also important in the context of

WHAT BEGINS AS A NOSTALGIC WHATSAPP REUNION EVOLVES INTO A POWERFUL conversation ON CASTE, PRIVILEGE AND THE MEANING OF EQUALITY

the 'Simon Go Back' call of the Congress. This was followed by the Round Table Conferences and the Communal Award of 1932, which created a separate electoral college for the Depressed Classes. The 1932 Poona Pact accepted the principle of reserved seats in legislatures, but the Depressed Classes were counted as Hindus. The constitutional provisions were the tenth milestone: Articles 14, 15, 16, 17 (Fundamental Rights), 46 & 335 (Directive Principles of State Policy), Articles 330 & 332 (political reservation in legislatures), Articles 338 & 338A (National Commission for SCs/STs), and Articles 341 & 342 (Presidential power to notify SCs and STs). The eleventh point was on the guidelines for the implementation of the Mandal Commission recommendations for OBCs. The *Indira Sawhney* judgement of 1992 froze the reservation cap at 50%, besides not extending benefits to promotion. The last milestone relates to the 103rd CSTA of 2019, which breached the 50% quota for the EWS.

SOCIETY AND SOCIAL MEDIA

Buttressed by these arguments, KM was able to speak facts with firm equanimity and without anger. And finally, when the group met again physically in the city of Nagpur, all members raised a toast to 'friendship, the ultimate affirmative action'. That this conversation had a positive ending is indeed heartening, because I am aware—both from my personal experience and the anecdotal recall of others—that these discussions can indeed be quite toxic. And let me also confess and question: but for reservations, would I have made the friends I did while at JNU (1979–1982) and in the Service (1985–2021)? In the interregnum of three years that I worked in *The Times of India* (1982–1985), there was not a single Dalit in either the newsroom or the editorial desk.

On behalf of Team VoW, I would like to congratulate the publisher of this book, Sujit Murmade, for ensuring that the manuscript has seen the light of day. For even after eight decades of Independence, the fact that, as a society and a nation, these fault lines continue to define our public discourse is proof enough that travellers on the journey of the 'Annihilation of Caste' are 'Still Waiting for a Visa'.

WELLNESS

ETHICS OF LETTING GO



Advances in critical care have prolonged life, but they have also forced society to reconsider where treatment ends and dignity begins

AUTHOR



ERA DUTTA

Most people are not afraid of death itself. What they fear is the possibility of a prolonged, dependent and undignified dying process.

Few medical debates make people as uncomfortable as euthanasia. Perhaps because it forces us to confront a truth that modern medicine has complicated. Today, technology allows us to keep the human body alive far longer than nature once intended. Ventilators, feeding tubes, dialysis and advanced critical care have dramatically extended life. But they have also raised an uncomfortable question: when does treatment begin to prolong suffering rather than life?

India recently revisited this question after the Supreme Court reaffirmed the legality of passive euthanasia under strict safeguards. This judgement reflects years of legal, medical and ethical deliberation. At the centre of the debate lies a simple yet profound idea: the right to die with dignity.

WHAT IS EUTHANASIA?

Euthanasia refers to intentionally ending a person's life to relieve unbearable suffering caused by severe or irreversible illness. Broadly, there are two kinds of euthanasia – active and passive. The distinction is crucial. One actively causes death. The other allows nature to take its course when treatment no longer serves a meaningful purpose.

HOW EUTHANASIA IS CARRIED OUT MEDICALLY

In countries where euthanasia or assisted dying is legal, the process follows rigorous protocols. Active euthanasia

generally involves a sequence of medications administered by physicians. A sedative is first given to induce deep sleep, followed by drugs that suppress breathing and eventually stop the heart. Multiple medical opinions, psychiatric evaluation and documented consent are required.

Physician-assisted dying works slightly differently. Here, the doctor prescribes a lethal medication, but the patient must take it themselves. This model exists in places such as Switzerland and several states in the United States.

Passive euthanasia, the form permitted in India, usually involves withdrawing life support in patients with irreversible illness. Doctors may discontinue ventilators or artificial feeding while

ensuring adequate pain relief and sedation. The focus shifts from aggressive treatment to palliative care and comfort.

INDIA'S LEGAL JOURNEY

The case that first brought this issue into public consciousness was the Aruna Shanbaug case in 2011. Shanbaug, a nurse at Mumbai's KEM Hospital, remained in a persistent vegetative state for more than four decades after a brutal assault. While the Supreme Court rejected active euthanasia, it permitted passive euthanasia under strict judicial supervision.

A more decisive shift came in 2018 with the Common Cause judgment, where the Supreme Court ruled that the right to die with dignity is part of the fundamental right to life. The court also recognised living wills, allowing individuals to document their wishes regarding life support in advance.

More recently, cases such as that of Harish Rana, a paralysed man seeking permission for passive euthanasia, have again drawn attention to the real human suffering behind this legal debate.

FOR DOCTORS, euthanasia is never a straightforward decision

WHERE EUTHANASIA IS LEGAL

Several countries have legalised euthanasia or assisted dying under strict safeguards. These include the Netherlands, Belgium, Luxembourg, Canada, Spain and Colombia. Other jurisdictions permit physician-assisted dying rather than direct euthanasia, including Switzerland and parts of Australia.

In the United States, assisted dying laws exist in states such as Oregon, Washington, California, Colorado, Vermont, Maine, New Jersey, Hawaii and New Mexico, along with the District of Columbia.

MEDIA PORTRAYAL

The Hindi film *Guzaarish*, starring Hrithik Roshan, told the story of a paralysed magician who petitions the court for euthanasia, bringing the debate about autonomy and dignity into public conversation.

THE ETHICAL DILEMMA

For doctors, euthanasia is never a straightforward decision. Psychiatry plays an important role in ensuring that such requests arise from clear decision-making rather than untreated depression, coercion or temporary distress.

Ultimately, the debate around euthanasia is not about choosing death over life. It is about recognising that medicine must not only prolong life, but also preserve dignity when life reaches its most fragile stage.

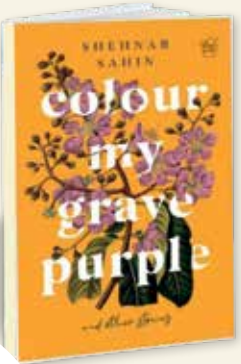
Echoes of Assam's Forgotten Past

In *Colour My Grave Purple*, Shehnab Sahin traces Assam's journey from colonial rule to modern India through 10 evocative stories rooted in history and memory

RAJESH OP SINGH

Assam occupies a position of immense strategic and geopolitical importance for India, serving not only as a vital state in its own right but also as the principal gateway to the northeastern region. Given this significance, citizens of India must possess a nuanced understanding of Assam's historical, social, and political trajectory. In her debut work, *Colour My Grave Purple*, former administrator Shehnab Sahin offers an insightful and carefully curated exploration of this complex past. This book is a unique collection of 10 historical stories that narrate Assam's remarkable journey from 1850 to 2000, presenting the state's people and everyday life through Assamese culture in a fresh and balanced perspective. The book's strength lies in its interweaving of Assam's colonial past, wartime encounters, and personal traumas into broader themes of resistance and belonging. This book explores Assam's history before and after major events in the country. What impact did these events have on Assam? What was the Assamese people's response?

The author blends social issues from her own experience with historical fiction, creating a sensibility in her stories that keeps



SET AT DIFFERENT TIMES, SHEHNAB'S characters ARE WRITTEN WITH A KEEN ATTENTION TO SYMBOLISM & SOCIAL CONTEXT

readers engaged. For instance, when writing about peasant movements, she linked them to homosexuality, as the homosexual community constantly rebelled for their rights, as did the peasants. Similarly, Ursula Graham Bower, a British anthropologist who visited Assam at that time, is imagined from the perspective of the Naga communities she studied.

Shehnab's opening story, "Two Leaves and a Bud" (1855), brings readers to the formative years of the region's tea plantations, when land appropriation and labour exploitation were at their peak,

told through the perspective of a British plantation manager. The story offers an unflinching look at the human cost behind the rise of Assam's tea economy. In her subsequent story, "Bellows of a Willed Poppy" (1860), the author explores the ongoing conflict between indigenous healing methods and colonial medicine. Through the character of Rebo, a traditional doctor who experiments with opium, the story emphasises how imperial systems of

knowledge sought to dominate and erase Assamese indigenous knowledge. The story underscores the epistemological violence embedded within colonial rule.

In "Freedom in My Blood" (1920), Shehnab shifts focus to highlighting the limits of political freedom within entrenched social structures, and she writes about how a young woman's involvement in the nationalist movement sparks political awakening for women but fails to translate it into personal liberation. The subsequent stories delve into the decades after independence, mapping change and continuity in equal measure.

These stories, bound together by geography and emotional resonance, flow steadily across time, echoing the rhythm of the Brahmaputra. Rather than presenting a straightforward story of Assam's progress, this book rejects the tendency to portray the Northeast as a problematic or peripheral region. Instead, it foregrounds local voices, internal conflicts, and the subtle, often overlooked consequences of power that seldom find space in mainstream historical accounts.

Through this book, Shehnab seeks to reclaim and revive the experiences of the Assamese rebellion and reaffirm the region's distinct identity within the nation's literary imagination.



Belgium may be small enough to cross in hours, yet its political and cultural divides make it one of Europe’s most fascinating puzzles

AUTHOR



VINOD KUMAR

Small Country Big Divides

From the window, the Hooghly curled like a dark ribbon under the wing lights, and the city slowly dissolved into scattered orange dots. Airports have a strange democracy — tired families, business travellers glued to laptops, a backpacker chasing Europe — all momentarily suspended between places. As the aircraft climbed into the quiet blue darkness, the television screens flickered with news updates about the escalating Iran-Israel-US conflict. Flights across parts of the Middle East had been disrupted and rerouted because of the war, a reminder that even the most personal journeys unfold against the restless stage of geopolitics.

Somewhere over the Arabian Sea, the cabin lights dimmed, and the aircraft settled into that long transcontinental silence. I thought of how strange travel is: you leave a noisy Indian city and wake up in another civilisation entirely. By the time the plane descended toward Brussels, dawn had begun spreading a pale gold across the sky. Belgium appeared first as neat fields and orderly towns, so different from Kolkata’s sprawling unpredictability. The runway glistened faintly under morning drizzle — the kind of European rain that seems to whisper rather than fall.

Brussels greeted me with the quiet efficiency of a city used to strangers. The airport train slid into the city centre, passing through suburbs where brick houses stood with the calm dignity of centuries. Soon the streets began to narrow, and the architecture changed — ornate buildings, tall windows, and cobblestone squares that looked as if history had been polished



rather than erased. Brussels, after all, grew into a major European trading centre centuries ago and today stands as both Belgium’s capital and the political heart of the European Union.

Yet what struck me first was not the monuments but the pace. The city seemed to move gently, almost thoughtfully. A café owner wiped tables while humming something in French. Cyclists glided past without honking. For someone arriving from Kolkata — where traffic horns are practically a language — the quiet felt almost surreal.

Belgium itself is a rather curious country. Around twelve million people live here, but the nation is divided into distinct linguistic worlds. The north, Flanders, speaks Dutch. The southern region, Wallonia, speaks French. Then there is Brussels — the capital — officially bilingual, though the reality often feels more complicated. A Walloon might rarely speak Dutch; a Fleming might avoid French. Someone once joked that the Belgian national football team uses English because it is the only language everyone understands.

The linguistic divide seeps into politics as well. Belgium’s governments are famously fragile coalitions stitched together from multiple parties representing

different regions and identities. It once took more than 500 days to form a government here, and another coalition required nearly two years of negotiations. For such a small country — one you can drive across in a few hours — the political machinery can seem surprisingly unwieldy. Yet the country functions, quietly and efficiently, as if accustomed to living with its own contradictions.

Later that afternoon, I reached the Grand Place, the famous square at the heart of Brussels. Its guildhalls glittered under the afternoon sun like elaborate wedding cakes carved in stone. Tourists wandered slowly, pointing at sculptures and towers, but the square itself had the air of a theatre that had seen centuries of performances. Belgium, for all its small size, carries a remarkable cultural legacy — folklore festivals, parades, medieval towns and culinary traditions that stretch far beyond its borders.

Standing there, I remembered another square thousands of kilometres away — College Street crossing in Kolkata. It too has history layered into its pavements, though the architecture is less polished and the chaos far more enthusiastic. In Kolkata, tea sellers shout over the rumble of buses; in Brussels, waiters glide quietly with trays of waffles and coffee. Yet both places share something oddly similar: the sense that people linger. Cities where

people linger always feel alive.

One evening, I wandered into a small café near the Sablon district. The menu proudly announced Belgian specialities — waffles, fries, and beer brewed in monasteries. Belgium is famous for these simple pleasures, along with its chocolates and its deeply rooted culinary culture.

The waiter asked where I was from. When I said Kolkata, he smiled as if he knew the city only from stories.

I told him about tramlines and Durga Puja pandals glowing like temporary palaces.

He nodded politely and then said something unexpected.

“Your city must be very loud.”

I laughed. “Yes,” I said. “But the noise is part of its soul.”

Later that night, back in my hotel room, I turned on the television. News channels continued to debate the widening war in West Asia. Oil prices were surging, and analysts warned that the conflict between Iran, Israel and the United States could reshape global politics and energy markets.

It felt strange to watch these reports while sitting in the peaceful heart of Europe. Brussels, with its diplomatic

buildings and careful neutrality, seemed far removed from missile strikes and airspace closures. Yet the war hovered invisibly even here — in flight paths, fuel prices, and anxious headlines.

Travel often reveals these invisible threads. You begin to see how connected the world really is. A conflict thousands of kilometres away can alter airline routes, change conversations in cafés, or even shape the mood of travellers. The global map is less a collection of borders than a network of ripples.

The next morning, I walked through Parc de Bruxelles, where the early light filtered through bare trees and pigeons strutted with aristocratic confidence. The calm reminded me unexpectedly of the Maidan in Kolkata on a winter morning — that brief hour when the city breathes slowly before the day erupts into noise.

Cities, I realised, are like people. They carry different temperaments but share similar rhythms — waking, working, worrying, celebrating. Brussels may be the bureaucratic capital of Europe, with its museums, historic squares and diplomatic corridors, but it also feels like a city comfortable with contemplation.

And perhaps that is what travel ultimately teaches. You arrive expecting difference — new food, new architecture, new languages. But somewhere between a Belgian café and a Kolkata memory, you begin to notice the quiet similarities instead.

On my last evening in Brussels, the sky turned pink over the rooftops and church towers. People gathered in small groups in the square, sipping beer and laughing softly. For a moment, the world felt strangely balanced — a peaceful European evening unfolding even as distant wars filled the news.

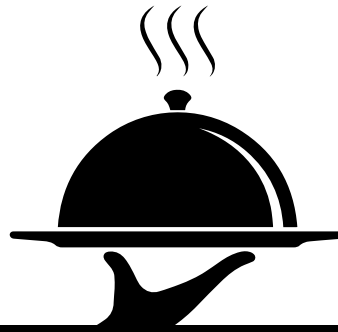
I thought again of that night flight leaving Kolkata, the city shrinking beneath the wing lights. Travel does not erase the world’s troubles. But it reminds us that beyond every headline there are ordinary streets, quiet cafés and conversations — small islands of normal life holding their ground against the storm.

BELGIUM



BELGIUM ONCE SPENT 541 DAYS WITHOUT A GOVERNMENT, YET PUBLIC SERVICES AND DAILY LIFE CONTINUED SMOOTHLY

BELGIUM’S POLITICAL SYSTEM IS AMONG THE MOST complex in Europe, OFTEN REQUIRING BROAD MULTI-PARTY COALITIONS TO GOVERN



GASTRONOMY

WOODLAND CHICKEN RICE



INGREDIENTS

- » Cooked rice 2 cups
- » Boneless chicken, small pieces 200 grams
- » Mushrooms, sliced 1 cup
- » Vegetable oil or sesame oil 2 tablespoons
- » Garlic, finely chopped 3 cloves
- » Ginger, finely chopped 1 inch
- » Spring onions, chopped 2 (white and green parts separated)
- » Onion, finely chopped 1 small
- » Carrot, finely chopped 1 small
- » Cabbage, shredded ½ cup
- » Soy sauce 1 tablespoon
- » Vinegar 1 teaspoon
- » Black pepper powder ½ teaspoon
- » Salt to taste
- » Green chilli sauce (optional) 1 teaspoon
- » Butter (optional) 1 tablespoon

DIRECTIONS

Heat a wok or a large pan on high flame. Add one tablespoon oil and cook the chicken pieces with a pinch of salt and pepper for about 4-5 minutes until they turn lightly golden and are fully cooked. Remove the chicken from the pan and set aside. In the same pan, add the remaining oil. Add the chopped garlic and ginger and sauté briefly until aromatic. Add the chopped onion and cook on high heat for about a minute until it turns slightly translucent. Add the sliced mushrooms and stir-fry until they soften and release their moisture. Once the mushrooms begin to brown lightly, add the chopped carrot and shredded cabbage. Stir-fry the vegetables for another minute so they remain crisp. Return the cooked chicken to the pan and mix well with the vegetables. Add the cooked rice and gently break any lumps with a spatula. Toss the rice over high heat so that it mixes evenly with the chicken and vegetables. Add soy sauce, vinegar, black pepper and salt if required. If you prefer a little heat, add green chilli sauce. Continue tossing the rice for two to three minutes so that it absorbs the flavours evenly. Finally add butter and the green parts of the spring onions. Toss everything once more and serve hot.



TIP



For the best fried rice texture, use rice that has been cooked earlier and cooled completely, preferably refrigerated for a few hours.



'WE SHOULD SUBSCRIBE TO ALL KINDS OF CINEMA'

Taapsee Pannu said that 'unconventional stories are on verge of becoming extinct species'

Taapsee Pannu believes women-led and unconventional films are on the verge of becoming 'extinct' as there is a lack of support from audiences for such stories.

Pannu, who has seamlessly balanced both mainstream and offbeat cinema, has built a reputation as a dependable performer and featured in a series of hard-hitting dramas such as 'Thappad', 'Mulk' and 'Pink'.

According to the actress, the battle to bring unconventional stories to the big screen has become harder. "We are on the verge of becoming an extinct species; we mean films like 'Assi'. There is a certain template that our so-called commercial cinema abides by and we don't conventionally fall in that template of sorts," Pannu told PTL.

'Assi' is Pannu's latest movie with acclaimed filmmaker Anubhav Sinha and marks their third collaboration after 2018's 'Mulk' and 'Thappad' in 2020.

The actress debunked the notion that such films will always find a home on digital platforms, saying that the streamers have shifted their focus to luring 'massy' audiences. "The reality is people think that these kinds of films will keep coming on OTT and we will keep watching them. But no, OTTs don't want these kinds of films either. They have clear mandates - that only the films that are working in theatres are the films that they want to pick. They want to take that theatre audience to their platform. They are like, 'We already have this kind of audience. We want those massy pot boiler audiences of our country to subscribe to the platform'. That's why I say we are on the verge of becoming extinct unless people realise that we need to watch it. Sometimes it's good to watch reality as well," Pannu added.

Comparing cinema to a range of cuisines, the 38-year-old actress said that while 'Mughlai', which is the commercial cinema, has its appeal, the industry also needs its 'dal chawal': stories rooted in everyday reality. She also believes that the habit of waiting for a digital release of a film is 'suicidal' for the future of meaningful cinema.

"We should subscribe to all kinds of cinema. Only the audience can help us by going to theatres and watching (all kinds of) films. I hope they realise this before we lose this. Then we won't have the right to crib that our cinema can't compete with world cinema; we only make a particular kind of film. We have a lot of people saying we don't make good



went with a bunch of lawyers and saw a female (public prosecutor); she was going through files diligently and the lawyers told me that, 'She must be just studying the case now'. It's like how you are studying just before the exam, kind of a vibe. So, this was different from what we imagined in our heads. So, I started realising, 'Why do I need to play it cold, up till a particular point at least?'"

'Assi' also stars Manoj Pahwa, Kumud Mishra, Kani Kusruti, Mohd Zeeshan Ayyub, Supriya Pathak, Revathi and Naseeruddin Shah. PTL

and rooted stories. But when did you support rooted stories? Sitting at home and watching it on OTT is not how you support good cinema. If you like the film, spread the word; let more people come into theatres."

Reflecting on her journey, Pannu said leading a film to release today feels like a 'daily pain' and a constant 'battle'. She believes the scenario changed post-COVID-19 pandemic. "Victories are way less than the battles that actors like me go through. One is the battle to get a film through. With this film, because he (Sinha) was there, I didn't have to think of a lot of things. There are scripts that I really like, but I need someone to believe that it is going to work or it is the right film to do. It's difficult for a female actor who is headlining a film, no matter how many successful films you've given in the past," she added.

Pannu struck a hopeful note as she said the success of Rani Mukherji's 'Mardaani 3' feels like a 'victory' for women across the industry. "Any other female actor's victory helps me. So, that's why I'm celebrating 'Mardaani 3' success because I know it will open up windows for a lot of movies that are driven by female actors," she said.

Taapsee hopes that 'Assi', which explores the growing cases of sexual violence against women, will be well-received in theatres. "By the virtue of being a woman, a lot of things (referring to her angst) will come naturally, but on this I had to work on not making it obvious that I'm emotionally invested as I'm doing my job," Pannu said.

The courtroom thriller features the actress in the role of public prosecutor Raavi. To prepare for her role, Pannu visited Patiala House Court to observe the real-world legal proceedings and added that this exercise helped her to balance 'professional coldness' with 'emotional depth' that was required for her character.

"I didn't come across a sexual assault case during my visit. I

THE ACTRESS RECENTLY STARRED IN THE FILM 'ASSI' DIRECTED BY ANUBHAV SINHA



EMERALD FENNEL'S 'WUTHERING HEIGHTS'

An emotive & visceral experience



Oscar-nominated Hollywood actress Margot Robbie produced and headlined the film

Hollywood star Margot Robbie said Emerald Fennell's 'Wuthering Heights' isn't just another faithful adaptation of author Emily Brontë's classic novel, as the filmmaker tried to recreate the feeling she had when she first read it as a teenager in her version.

The Oscar-nominated actress produced and headlined the film. She stars alongside fellow Australian star Jacob Elordi.

Brontë's 1847 novel is considered one of the most intense and haunting love stories in English literature as it traces the destructive, all-consuming bond between Heathcliff and Catherine Earnshaw, a relationship driven as much by obsession, pride and revenge as by love.

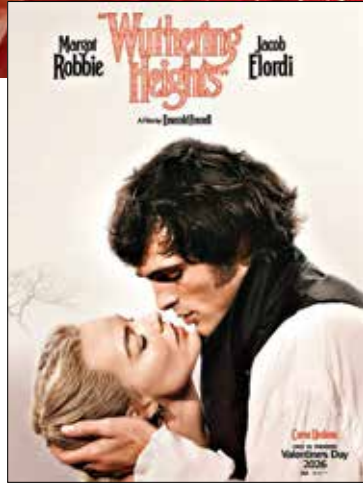
Fennell, known for directing critically acclaimed movies 'Promising Young Women' and 'Saltburn', adapted the screenplay and directed the new movie.

"It's a bold interpretation of one of the greatest love stories of all time, a book that she (Fennell) loves dearly and I love, too. It has been adapted and interpreted many, many times over the years. I think what Emerald wanted to do was recreate the feeling the book gave her the first time she read it when she was 14 years old. And so, what you get with Emerald's 'Wuthering Heights' is a very emotive and visceral experience. It's very much focusing on how what's happening is making you feel," Robbie said in a transcript shared by 'Warner Bros India'.

As a filmmaker, Fennell puts a 'distinctive and unique stamp' on her work that is able to elicit a visceral reaction from the audience, Robbie added.

"She does that in a different way in this film, but it is, like I said, a very visceral experience. It's very emotional. It's very romantic and it's epic. It's storytelling on a really big scale," she said.

The novel has been adapted in Hollywood in 1920, 1939, 1970,



She starred alongside fellow Australian star Jacob Elordi

1992, 2011 and 2022. The story has had multiple adaptations in Bollywood as well, with Dilip Kumar starring in three movies: 'Arzoo' in 1950, 'Hulchul' in 1951 and 'Dil Diya Dard Liya' in 1966.

Robbie, who broke out as a star with Martin Scorsese's 'The Wolf of Wall Street' and has solidified her career with 'I, Tonya', 'Once Upon a Time in Hollywood', 'Bombshell' and 'Barbie', said she has often wondered what makes 'Wuthering Heights' a story that filmmakers keep returning to.

"The answer is, I don't know and if I did know, I don't know if we'd still be examining it 200 years later. But I suspect it's got something to do with how challenging these characters are, how much you want things to work out for them, how their relationship is so difficult and complex and yet so straightforward at the same time."

Robbie and Elordi's chemistry garnered a lot of attention in the film, to which the actress said that Fennell, who worked with Elordi earlier in 'Saltburn', wrote Heathcliff with him in mind.

"It's because she said he looked like the illustration of Heathcliff on the cover of the book that she read when she was a teenager, which I love. For me, Heathcliff is a lineage of actors... I think of Laurence Olivier famously playing Heathcliff and Ralph Fiennes and Tom Hardy and it feels fitting to me that Jacob should play Heathcliff, given that I think he is going to be one of the great actors of our generation. He's already proving to be that," she said. PTL



WHAT'S COMING NEXT?

OUR CORRESPONDENT

From 'The Plastic Detox' to 'Homicide: New York' S2, here is a selection of new OTT offerings for you to enjoy

THE PLASTIC DETOX

To be released on March 16, the 'Netflix' documentary explores the impact of microplastics and chemicals on human health, specifically fertility, along with six couples attempting to avoid any usage of plastic.



IMPERFECT WOMEN



Starring Elisabeth Moss, Kerry Washington and Kate Mara in lead roles, the 'Apple TV+' series follows an investigation that plunges deep into the murder of a wealthy woman and every single dark secret uncovered about her life. It'll premiere on March 18.

PEAKY BLINDERS: THE IMMORTAL MAN

As Cillian Murphy reprises his role as Tommy Shelby, the 'Netflix' film, set to be released on March 20, will witness Tommy return to a bombed Birmingham — only to get involved in secret wartime missions during World War II while facing new enemies.



DAREDEVIL: BORN AGAIN S2



Charlie Cox returns as the greatest bada** 'Marvel' hero and a fighter in the new season, which will be available for streaming on March 24 on 'Jio Hotstar'. It'll continue the intense conflict between Matt Murdock (Cox) and Wilson Fisk.

HOMICIDE: NEW YORK S2

To premiere on March 25, the new 'Netflix' true crime docuseries will see five hour-long episodes full of intense, real-life murder cases in New York City, along with interviews of the investigators and prosecutors.

